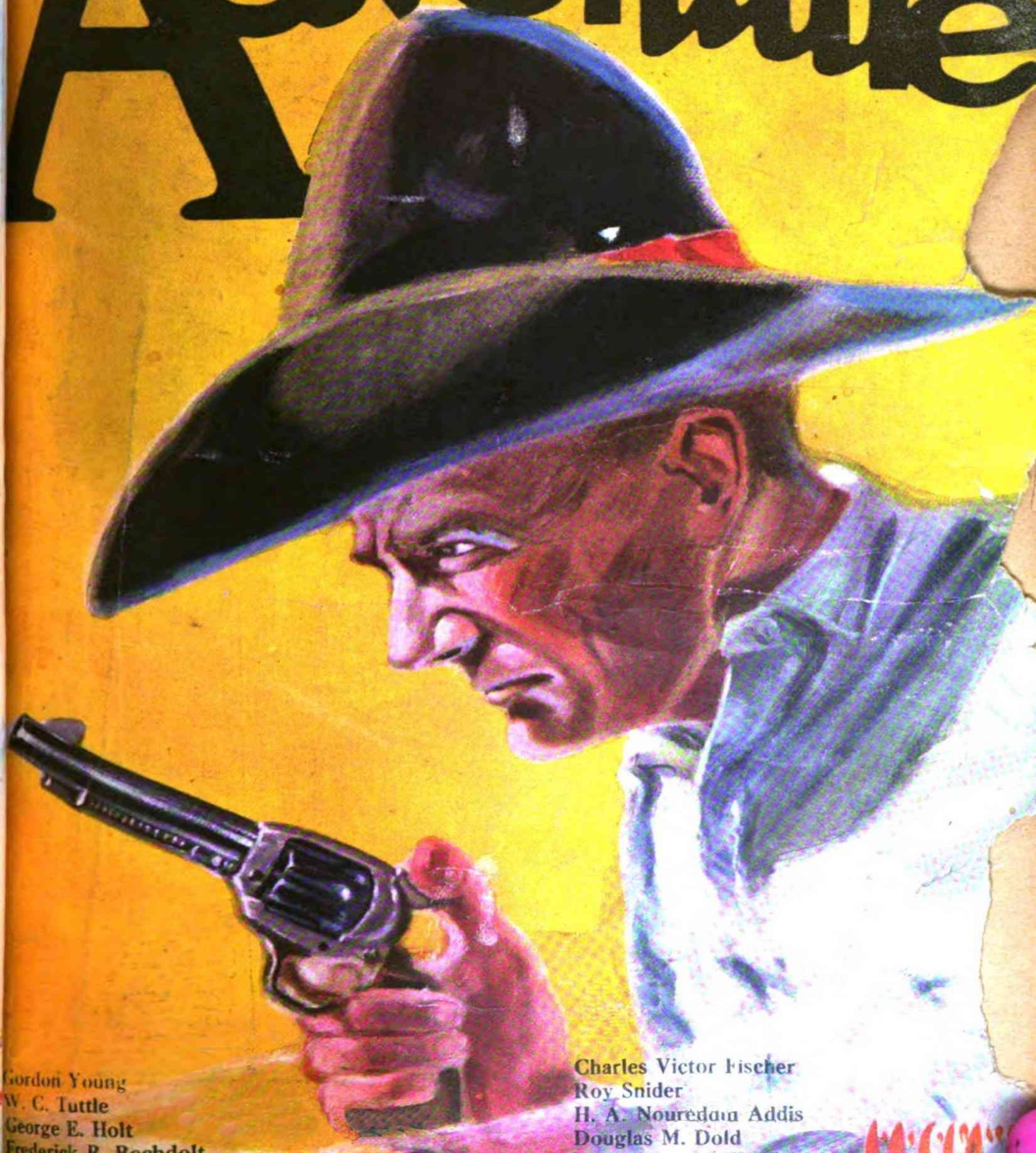


JUNE
30th
1923
25c

PUBLISHED
THREE TIMES A MONTH

Adventure



Gordon Young
W. C. Tuttle
George E. Holt
Frederick R. Boebdelt

Charles Victor Fischer
Roy Snider
H. A. Nouredoun Addis
Douglas M. Dold

JUNE

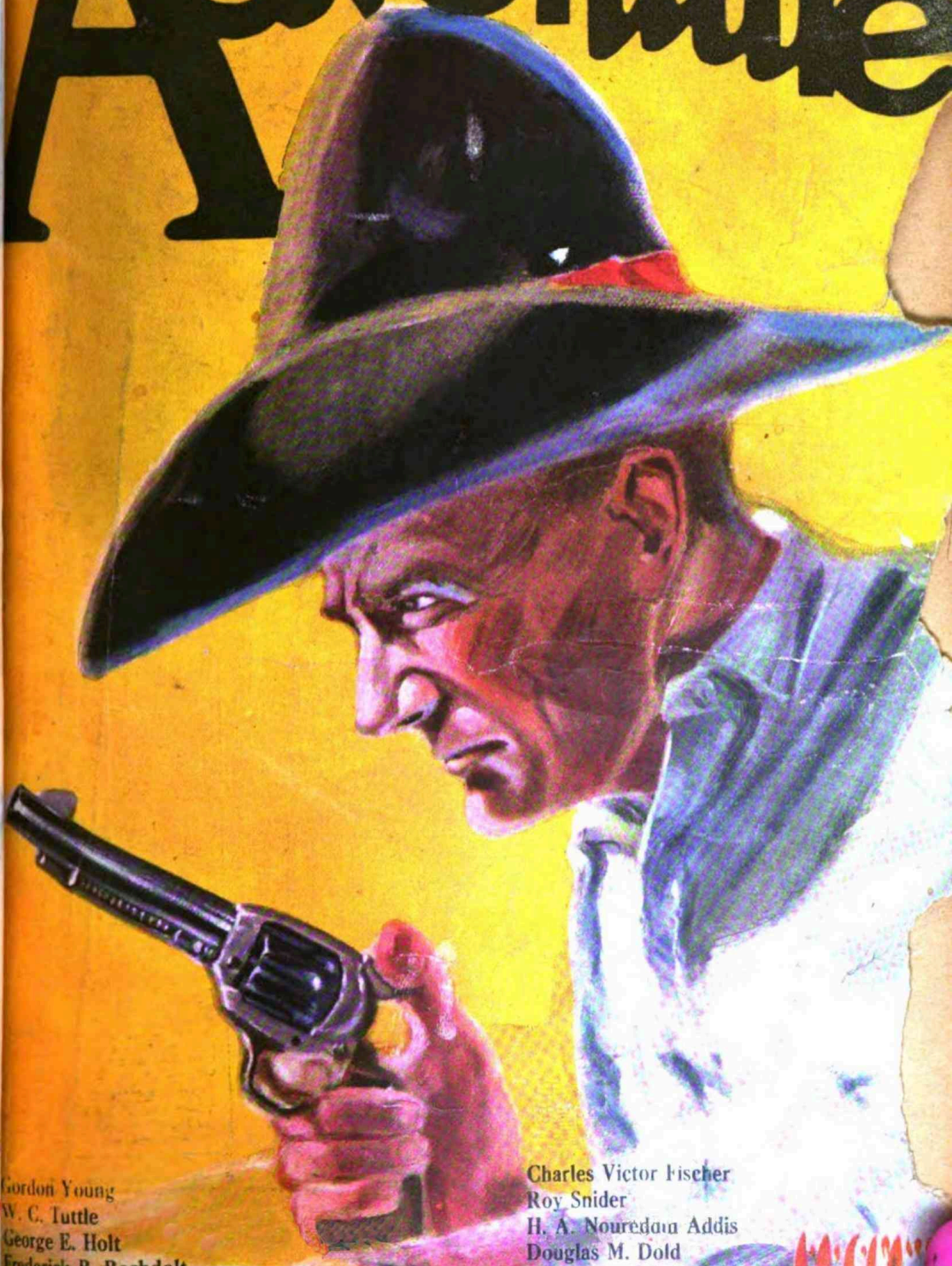
30th

1923

25c

PUBLISHED
THREE TIMES A MONTH

Adventure



Gordon Young
W. C. Tuttle
George E. Holt
Frederick B. Rockdell

Charles Victor Fischer
Roy Snider
H. A. Noureddin Addis
Douglas M. Dold

The Project Gutenberg eBook of The misdeal

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

Title: The misdeal

Author: W. C. Tuttle

Release date: May 12, 2026 [eBook #78659]

Language: English

Original publication: New York, NY: The Ridgway Company, 1923

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/78659

Credits: Prepared by volunteers at BookCove (bookcove.net)

*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE MISDEAL



THE MISDEAL

By W. C. Tuttle

Author of "Tramps of the Range," "Sticky Ropes," etc.

"I tell yuh he did make out a will! You're danged right he did! That day he had Williams, the lawyer, from Broken Butte he made out that will. Aw-w-w, ——, you make me tired!"

"Wheezer" Bell spat angrily and hammered his boot-heel against the wall of the NR bunk-house. Wheezer was half-inclined to be mad at "Leather" Kleig, who was humped up in the shade, his thin, impassive face hidden under the brim of his wide sombrero.

"Chet" Wells, a broken-nosed, scar-faced cowboy, was stretched out, half in shade, half in sun, chewing a big portion of tobacco; while just beyond him sat "Wooden-shoe" Van Dorn, a fat, stolid-faced, pig-eyed cowboy.

"You engineered this deal, Leather——" Wheezer stopped hammering the bunk-house wall and glared down at the top of Leather's hat—"and you sure raised —— and put a block under it, if anybody rises from the dead to inquire."

Leather did not look up, but said slowly——

“Wheezer, you’re talkin’ too —— much!”

“Well, there ain’t no use of talkin’—much,” observed Wooden-shoe slowly, “and we don’t want to make trouble among us, do we, Wheezer?”

“Aw, I ain’t huntin’ trouble,” Wheezer assured him, “but we ain’t got a —— thing t’ show that the NR owes us a danged thing.”

“True as gospel preachin’,” agreed Chet warmly. “If Leather’d only said like this to the old man: You write——”

“Now, you’re gettin’ the tongue-trouble, too, eh?” interrupted Leather ominously, but did not look up.

Wheezer shoved away from the wall and stepped around in front of Leather Kleig, his thumbs hooked over the top of his cartridge-belt.

“Kleig, if you think for a minute that you can stop me from talkin’—cut yore wolf loose.” Wheezer’s voice was pitched low, but was full of meaning. “You’ve bossed this outfit too —— much; *sabe?* We’ve been gypped out of everythin’. Now, put up or shut up.”

Kleig did not move, but his eyes flashed to Wheezer for a second.

“Like I said before,” stated Wooden-shoe impassively, “we shouldn’t quarrel among us. Whatcha say, Wheezer? Let’s all be good little friends together.”

“Thassall right,” nodded Leather. “I ain’t sayin’ that I didn’t make a mistake, but yuh gotta agree that I lose as much as you fellers do.”

“Sure, sure,” agreed Chet indifferently. “I heard the old man tell yuh that he was goin’ to sell the NR and split the pot. Yuh can’t blame Leather ’cause the old man decides to die off, can yuh, Wheezer?”

“’S far as that’s concerned—no,” admitted Wheezer. “But it sure leaves us high and dry, Chet.”

Wooden-shoe suddenly burst into a dry chuckle.

“Now, what in —— are you laughin’ at?” demanded Chet.

“Just laughin’,” replied Wooden-shoe. “Here we’ve been stealin’ stock for over a year for old Nick Ralls, and ain’t got nothin’ for ourselves.”

“Except experience,” said Wheezer gloomily.

All of which was both sad and true. Many years previous to this time, Nick Ralls, an old gun-man of the Southwest, had migrated to the Broken

Butte ranges and taken up the NR ranch. Nick Ralls was a bitter old codger, quick of temper, and very flexible of conscience.

He did not prosper, but made a living. There were few NR cows on the Broken Buttes when Leather Kleig, Wheezer Bell, Wooden-shoe Van Dorn and Chet Wells rode into the yard of the tumble-down ranch-house and informed old Nick that they were both hungry and tired.

The sheriff of the adjoining county lost them in the breaks and went home disgusted; but they did not know this. They needed sanctuary, and old Nick Ralls gave it to them, because he recognized them as kindred spirits.

Old Nick was growing old—raspingly old. The Broken Butte range was a fertile field for those who carried a running-iron and little regard for the law. And when the adjoining county had practically forgotten the four men who attempted to rob the bank at Dry Wells, the four men made an oral contract with old Nick Ralls.

Leather Kleig was a brand counterfeiter. His skill with a running-iron or razor was uncanny. Combination brands were an open book to him. Every animal that fell within their loop or corral was quickly made over into an NR, which would pass muster even on close examination, and old Nick Ralls chuckled evilly, while his herd grew until the hills of Broken Butte range were dotted with his possessions.

Then, as Wheezer described it:

“He ups and dies. And the or’nary old son-of-a-sea-cook knowed he was goin’ to die, didn’t he? Then why does he send for a lawyer to make out his will?”

All of which was not at all cheerful to the four men in the shade of the NR bunk-house.

“Yeah, it leaves us high and dry,” admitted Chet. “We ain’t got nothin’ to show for all our hard work. If yuh asks my opinion, I’d suggest that we all line up, give the word and all start shootin’. If there’s any survivor, he can take what money the other fellers has got and pull out.”

“Good idea!” exploded Wooden-shoe. “I’d like——”

“You would!” interrupted Wheezer sarcastically. “You ain’t got a danged cent to lose. Leather must have about six-bits, which is four-bits more than I’ve got. I dunno about Chet, but I reckon two-bits would about tap him.”

“Then that idea ain’t so good,” said Chet mournfully. “What’ll we do? Brand the NR cows all over and sell them to the sheriff?”

“——, the sheriff!” grunted Leather. “He’s too pious. Goes to church! —— deliver me from a church-goin’ sheriff.”

“One thing’s a cinch,” observed Chet thoughtfully. “If them misbranded critters are ever discovered, they can’t hang the deadwood on to us. We don’t own ’em. And no sensible man ever steals cows as a pastime.”

“I’m through stealin’ cows,” declared Wooden-shoe, emphatically. “I tell yuh, I’m through.”

“Reformin’, eh?” sneered Leather Kleig.

“Yeah, I’m goin’ to rob banks or trains—and I’m goin’ to steal for me; *sabe?*”

“We’re a —— of a fine bunch of outlaws,” declared Wheezer. “Bad men from Bitter Crick. ——! ’F we don’t look out, some old lady is goin’ to hoodle us off this range with a parasol.”

“For his heart was hard and so was his hide,
And the rattlesnake crawled away and died,
The da-a-a-y he bit Bill Jo-o-o-nos.”

Chet’s voice quavered lovingly on the last line, and his broken nose twitched feelingly.

“You can do a lot of things better than yuh can sing,” observed Wooden-shoe sadly. “You ought to twist yore ears a little, Chet. Yuh sound like a couple of yore strings was loose.”

“Bein’ funny ain’t gittin’ us no place——” Wheezer dug his heel into the hard dirt. “What are we goin’ to do? That’s the question. If old Ralls didn’t leave no will, I s’pose the whole works will be sold by the sheriff.”

“I’d love to set on a fence and see that —— sheriff sell my cows!” exploded Leather.

“What ’d yuh do?” asked Wheezer. “Would yuh tell him how it comes that yuh feel bad about it, Leather?”

“Talkin’ makes me hungry,” stated Wooden-shoe. “Let’s go and see what Ma Coogan’s got for supper.”

“And that’s another thing,” said Wheezer. “What in —— is goin’ to become of Ma Coogan?”

“Yessir, that’s another thing,” agreed Wooden-shoe.

Ma Coogan was the cook and housekeeper of the NR, and was as much a part of the ranch as the old ranch-house. She was about sixty years of age; thirty of which had been spent in the range country.

Ten years previous to this time, Jim Coogan and his wife had been nesters in the Broken Butte range. Nesters were not wanted, and old Jim had absorbed a bullet; which left Ma Coogan destitute.

Nick Ralls, whose heart was bitter against everything, and nesters in particular, had installed the old widow as cook and housekeeper in the NR. He swore at the time that he did not do it to be kind, but to prove that he could be contrary to his own nature.

Ma Coogan was a little woman, with a typically Irish face, a heart of gold, but with a tongue that proved to Nick Ralls the advisability of running his end of the ranch and not interfering with the household.

It was five days since the burial of Nick Ralls, and Ma Coogan was beginning to get back to normal. She had never considered what Ralls’ death might mean to her. She was sitting on the porch, as the four men came up to the ranch-house, fanning herself with a magazine.

“Ye’re all hungry, I suppose,” she remarked. “And what have ye done to make ye hungry, I’d ask? Are ye goin’ to sit in the shade all the rest of your life?”

“Looks kinda like it, Ma,” said Wheezer. “But what’s the use of workin’? There’s nobody to pay salaries.”

“Nobody?” Ma Coogan stopped fanning herself. “Nobody to pay—well, bless me soul!”

She stared at them and her eyes shifted to the hazy hills, as a sudden realization of things came to her.

“I never thought of that,” she said softly. “Nobody to pay salaries, nobody to run the ranch. Now, what’s to become of everybody, I’d like to know?”

Wheezer shook his head.

“I dunno, Ma. Do you remember that lawyer comin’ up here a couple of days before Nick Ralls died?”

“That fat, fish-eyed feller from Broken Butte? Aye, he was with Nick Ralls for a long time.”

“He’s a lawyer, Ma. We was wonderin’ if Nick made out a will. He knowed he was goin’ to die, I reckon.”

“He did that,” declared Ma. “Belike he heard the banshee wailin’; I dunno.”

“What’s a banshee, Ma?” asked Wooden-shoe.

“Sure, it’s an Irish ghost. When ye hear one wailin’, ye’r goin’ to die, Wooden-shoe. There’s a lot of thim that has heard the banshee.”

Leather Kleig laughed sarcastically.

“Ghosts! No ghost would wail over Nick Ralls. What I’d like to know: Did Nick Ralls make out a will?”

“There was such a thing mentioned,” said Ma slowly. “I heard thim speak of a will, and there was a paper that I had to sign me name to, but I did not read it.

“This fish-eyed feller he puts his finger on one spot, and he says for me to write me name there. Ould Nick says that I’m a witness. I dunno what it was all about, but it looked like some sort of a cer-ti-fic-it.”

“That was a will,” declared Wheezer. “Did he ever tell yuh about any of his relatives, Ma?”

“He did not, Wheezer. I misdoubt if he had any. But Nick Ralls was no man to blather about any one. Hated the world, so he did. He even swore at the lawyer. Well, the poor soul has gone to glory, and if I don’t go in and finish gittin’ supper, the rest of ye will be failin’ for want of food.”

“If Nick Ralls has gone to glory, I hope I don’t,” declared Leather Kleig. “He wasn’t entitled to it.”

“Aw, sure, now—” Ma Coogan turned at the doorway and looked down at Leather, “ye mustn’t wish ill of a dead man. He wasn’t all bad, Leather. Do ye think that God is goin’ to punish ye by sendin’ ye to a hot place? What would He gain by it, I’d ask ye? Would it be a lesson to thim that stayed behind in this life?”

“We wouldn’t see it. A lovin’ God wouldn’t git no satisfaction out of it, would He? Thin where is your reasons for a place of damnation, I dunno? I tell ye, I think that Nick Ralls went to glory.”

“All right, Ma,” said Leather gloomily. “I hope, if he has, that he can look down and see what a —— fool he was to leave the NR in this kinda shape.”

“Amen,” said Ma Coogan piously.

It was three days later that Eph Williams, the lawyer from Broken Butte, came again to the NR; and with him came Ben Murtch, the sheriff, and a lady.

The four cowboys looked with great disfavor upon Ben Murtch and Eph Williams, because they had little use for the law in any of its forms. But there was a certain amount of speculation regarding the lady.

Murtch was a bandy-legged person, broad-shouldered, and with a massive head. His features were of the type commonly known as bulldog, and he was reputed fast with a gun. On account of their wild doings in Broken Butte, Murtch had no use for the boys of the NR—and did not conceal his feelings.

Both Murtch and Williams attended the little church at Broken Butte, and at times Williams would pass the collection plate. The four cowboys from the NR went to church one Sunday night, more out of curiosity than from piety, and observed the actions of Williams and Murtch.

Hence Leather Kleig’s remark of—

“Lord deliver me from a church-goin’ sheriff.”

Williams, Murtch and the lady came out to the ranch in a top-buggy, and went straight to the ranch-house. The four cowboys sat at the bunk-house and speculated as to who the lady might be, until Murtch left the house and came down to see them.

“Howdy, boys,” he greeted them pleasantly, but they were not receptive to his greeting.

He stopped near them and hitched up his belt.

“Thought yuh might like to know who the lady is,” he remarked.

“Yeah?” Wheezer squinted sideways at him. “Yuh thought so, did yuh?”

“Yeah, I thought yuh would.”

“Reckon we ought to take a vote on it?” questioned Chet.

“That,” said Murtch, not a bit perturbed over their indifference, “that is Miss Jane Cleveland, who owns this ranch, lock, stock and barrel.”

“Oh, yeah!” Wheezer nodded quickly. “That’s who she is, eh?”

“Yeah, that’s her.”

“Who’s she?” Wooden-shoe hugged his knees and grinned at Murtch.

“That’s a —— of a question,” declared Murtch.

“It’s a good question, and there ought to be an answer layin’ around somewhere.”

Eph Williams was coming down from the house, and Murtch decided to wait and let him explain things.

“Fish-eye,” chuckled Wheezer. “Shore fits him.”

The rest of the cowboys grinned, and Eph looked uncomfortable, even if he did not know what had been said.

“Did you tell ’em, Murtch?” asked Williams. His voice was rather husky, as if suffering from a heavy cold.

“I left the job to you,” said Murtch. “You sabe it better than I do.”

“I sure as —— hope he does,” growled Leather.

“Well, it is simple,” smiled Williams. “Miss Cleveland just arrived from Helena to take charge of this ranch. Just before Nick Ralls passed on he had me make out his will. Miss Cleveland is the daughter of his only sister, and the only living relative of Nick Ralls. He had kept track of her all these years, and when he felt that his days were numbered, he sent for me, made out his will, and——” Williams spread his hands——“that is all there is to it.”

“Well, now, that’s quite a lot,” admitted Leather, and the other three cowboys knew what he meant.

“Miss Cleveland knows nothing about cattle,” stated Williams, “but she was more than willing to take charge. I do not know whether she will retain any or all of you boys. I have made no suggestions. As far as I can see there is no use of having four cowboys to handle the cattle, but I am leaving it to her to do things to suit herself.”

“That’s —— kind of yuh, I’m sure,” applauded Chet. “What did you say your business was?”

“I am an attorney-at-law,” said Williams stiffly.

“Oh, yeah—a lawyer?”

“Don’t waste words on ’em, Eph,” advised Murtch. “They’re tryin’ to get under your hide.”

“Wouldn’t be under it for the world,” denied Chet. “I’d smother t’ death in a minute.”

Williams whirled on his heel and went back toward the horse and buggy, walking stiff-legged, like an angry bear. Murtch looked after him and turned to the grinning cowboys.

“You fellers likely don’t know that Williams will have quite a lot to say about this place, do yuh? He’s goin’ to advise Miss Cleveland on business matters.”

“Lord help her,” said Wheezer sadly.

Murtch scowled and turned away, starting back to where Williams was getting into the buggy.

“You didn’t tell us what your business is,” reminded Wooden-shoe.

Murtch grunted something unintelligible, but did not turn his head.

They drove down past the bunk-house, on their way out of the ranch, but neither of them looked at the four grinning cowboys on the steps.

“A heiress,” said Wheezer dolefully. “A blasted heiress to our cows!”

“And a fish-eyed lawyer advisin’ her what to do with them,” added Chet. “If somebody’d stick a fork into us they’d find us well done.”

Chet got to his feet and executed a double-shuffle on the steps, while he sang sadly:

“Oh, Williams, yo’re a ——
Oh, Williams, yo’re a bum;
There’s nothin’ good about you,
And yore breath sure smells of rum.
Yo’re killin’ us by inches,
I know I am yore slave
But when you die, you son-of-a-gun,
I’ll dance upon yore grave.”

“That record sounds scratched,” observed Wheezer dryly. “Sounds like a Injun with hay-fever, tryin’ to give a imitation of C’ruso singin’ soprano.”

“Aw, ——!” Leather Kleig snorted his disgust and got to his feet. “Let’s go and meet the new boss.”

“Mebbe she’ll appreciate my voice,” said Chet hopefully. “I’ll take a chance.”

“I’ll shoot yuh, if yuh try singin’ to her,” threatened Wheezer, as they trooped to the ranch-house.

“Aw, he won’t make no never mind,” assured Wooden-shoe. “I hope he yodels and busts his windpipe.”

“What’s a yodel?” asked Wheezer.

Wooden-shoe stopped, pointed his nose toward the sky and began:

“Hi-i-i lee-e-e-e o la lay-ee-e-e— Leggo! Ouch!”

Wheezer and Chet had moved in swiftly beside him, each grabbing him by collar and boot and dumped him unceremoniously on top of his head. Then they let go at the same time and his heels hit the ground with a thud.

For a moment, Wooden-shoe’s breath was jarred from his body, and he lay there goggling at the sky.

“I hope he isn’t injured.”

The cowboys turned and stared at Jane Cleveland, who was standing on the porch, staring at Wooden-shoe, who sat up and puffed the atmosphere back into his lungs. He saw her and tried to laugh.

“No, ma’am,” said Wheezer foolishly. “You can’t hurt him.”

Wheezer had removed his hat, and now he stepped over, lifted Wooden-shoe’s hat off his head and placed it in his lap.

Jane Cleveland was a stately brunette, well-dressed, possibly twenty-five years of age. There was no question of her beauty, but it was marred a trifle by the superiority of her manner. She might well have been a queen, looking down upon them; making them feel rather out of place before her. Her lips lifted slightly in a semblance of a smile at Wheezer’s rough wit.

“You are the cowboys, I suppose?”

“Yes’m, I s’pose we are,” nodded Chet.

He looked at the other three and back at the girl.

“Yes’m, I’m sure of it now. Get up, Wooden-shoe. My gosh, you ain’t got no manners a-tall.”

“You’re Miss Cleveland, I s’pose,” observed Leather.

It was a perfect imitation of her question, and her eyes hardened slightly.

“Yes, I am Miss Cleveland, the owner of this farm.”

“My ——!” breathed Chet. “Farm!”

Ma Coogan had come out of the door, and Miss Cleveland turned.

“Was there something you wanted?”

“Nothin’, me dear,” said Ma Coogan.

“Then I think your place is in the kitchen—not on the veranda.”

Ma Coogan looked wonderingly at Miss Cleveland.

“Would ye mind sayin’ that again?”

“Are you not the cook?”

Miss Cleveland’s voice was icy.

“Yes, I’m the cook.”

“There is nothing to cook out here.”

“Well—” Ma Coogan swallowed painfully and looked appealingly at the four cowboys—“well, I s’pose that’s right. I never thought of that—in ten years.”

She turned and went back into the house. Leather Kleig cleared his throat, and his eyes narrowed dangerously, but Wheezer trod heavily on the side of his ankle and saved Leather from saying the wrong thing.

“I have not made up my mind what I am going to do with this place.” Miss Cleveland was talking, but the four boys were still staring at the doorway where Ma Coogan had disappeared and paid no attention to her.

“I would like to know just what I inherited from my uncle. Can you give me an estimate of how many cows, horses, etc., are included in this ranch?”

“Well—” Wheezer scratched his head thoughtfully—“that’s kinda hard, ma’am. There won’t be no round-up for a month, and ’till we kinda bunches them cows there ain’t no way of tellin’.”

“Didja know yore uncle very well?” asked Wooden-shoe.

“No, I never have seen him.”

“He didn’t have much sense, ma’am.”

“Is that so?” Miss Cleveland seemed indifferent to that statement.

“You goin’ to run the ranch yoreself, ma’am?” asked Leather.

“I suppose I will. Mr. Williams, the lawyer, will advise me in some of the details, and Mr. Murtch has offered his services at any time. Is there any reason why I cannot handle it?”

“Not with all that help—” Leather shook his head. “Of course you’ve got to hire some cowboys.”

“Naturally. Mr. Williams said that I could probably get along with less hired help than my uncle did. In fact, they informed me that every one wondered how uncle managed to make the ranch pay, with four cowboys in his employ.”

“Yeah, it is a wonder,” agreed Leather softly. “Yuh see, he hired us by the year and died two days before payday. This ranch owes us each four hundred and eighty dollars apiece.”

“Four hundred and eighty dollars apiece?”

“Yes’m,” said Wheezer grinning widely and making some rapid calculations. “The old NR owes us four punchers the grand total of nineteen hundred and twenty dollars.”

Wooden-shoe blinked and wet his lips with his tongue. He was a willing but slow liar, and he marveled at Leather telling a thing like that.

“And we sure worked faithful-like,” added Chet sadly. “A year’s a long time to go without a payday. ’Course the ranch is good for it, ma’am; so we ain’t worryin’.”

“Well,” said Miss Cleveland dubiously, “I know nothing about such things, but I shall take it up with Mr. Williams.”

“And Ma Coogan kinda got the worst of it,” said Wheezer mournfully. “Yuh see, when she goes to work for yore uncle, he says to her—

“ ‘If you work for me for ten years without pay, I’ll give yuh enough to keep yuh for the rest of yore life.’

“Well, she’s sure worked faithfully, y’betcha. It ain’t no cinch runnin’ her end of the job. Now, she’s old and can’t land no other job, but I reckon you’ll see that she gets what old Nick Ralls promised her.”

“But I know nothing about these things,” protested Miss Cleveland. “Is there any agreement—a written agreement, I mean?”

“Shucks, folks use their word instead of ink out here,” said Leather. “We’ve all heard Nick tell what he was goin’ to do for Ma Coogan. Why, jist the other day he says to me, like this—

“ ‘Leather, if anythin’ happens to me, will you see that Ma Coogan gits what’s comin’ to her?’

“I told him that I sure would, ma’am.”

“Why wasn’t she mentioned in the will?”

“I’ll tell yuh why, ma’am.” Chet moved in closer and lowered his voice. “Old Nick Ralls wasn’t in his right mind. He heard the banshee wailin’.”

“The—what do you mean?” Miss Cleveland frowned slightly. “What did he hear?”

“A banshee wailin’. There’s lot of ’em, ma’am. When yuh hear one, yuh might as well practise up on some kind of a harp, ’cause yuh ain’t got no chance left.”

“I do not think I understand—nor care. By the way, I do not know your names.”

“I’m Wheezer Bell,” Wheezer indicated himself. “That’s Leather Kleig. Got his front name from reachin’ for a saddle-horn so often. This’n,” pointing at Chet, “this’n is Chet Wells. He’s old man Wells’ son. That other one is Wooden-shoe Van Dorn, the only Dutch cowpuncher in captivity. He can squeak like a windmill, and he wakes up yelling at night, thinkin’ that the dykes have busted.”

“Thank you very much.”

She turned and went into the house.

The four cowboys looked at each other and went back to the bunk-house, where they draped themselves in the shade and stared at each other.

“Leather,” said Wheezer softly, “yo’re the first —— liar I ever loved. But can we work that idea?”

“Who in —— can say that we lied?” queried Chet. “Nick Ralls never kept no books.”

“I dunno—” Leather shook his head sadly—“I’m a son-of-a-gun if I ever seen a look on anybody’s face like there was on Ma’s, when Miss Cleveland ordered her back to the kitchen.”

“Aw, that was too bad,” nodded Wheezer, “and Ma took it, too.”

“Yeah, and we better kinda look a little out,” said Wooden-shoe. “She’d fire the whole bunch of us. There wasn’t no use lyin’ about Ma Coogan. Us liars can stick together, but Ma wouldn’t back us up.”

“She’s goin’ to be advised by Williams and helped by Murtch,” mused Leather aloud; “I dunno——”

He shook his head sadly and began manufacturing a cigaret.

“—— old Nick Ralls!” exploded Chet.

“He sure had a cause to keep away from his relation,” said Wheezer. “That woman ain’t got no heart, don’tcha know it?”

“Pretty ones hardly ever do have,” said Leather.

“You’ve knowed so many of them,” grinned Chet.

“I betcha she won’t eat at the table with us,” offered Wooden-shoe. “I betcha she makes Ma set a table in the front room for her.”

“I sure hope she does,” declared Chet. “If she don’t—we will. By golly, she’s pretty, though.”

“Yore rope’s draggin’,” cautioned Wheezer.

“Well, suppose it is, I didn’t say I was stuck on her, did I?”

“I suppose Wooden-shoe will be makin’ love to her pretty quick,” said Leather.

“No sir,” Wooden-shoe shook his head vehemently and his face flushed hotly. “I stole cows for a year for her, and that’s enough. She can’t expect too much.”

Ma Coogan’s hammering of the steel triangle, which hung at the kitchen-door, broke up the meeting, and the four cowboys trooped to the rear of the kitchen to wash up for supper.

There was no sign of the new owner, and Ma Coogan was strangely silent. Even the cowboys ate silently, which was unusual.

“My ——!” grunted Wheezer. “You’d think somebody done died around here.”

“Somethin’ has, I reckon,” whispered Chet seriously, and Ma Coogan shook her head warningly at him.

At the conclusion of the meal, which none of them enjoyed, Leather Kleig drew Ma Coogan out of the back door, while the others grouped close

around them.

“Ma,” said Leather, “did you know that Nick Ralls told you that, if yuh stayed here ten years, he’d fix yuh up so yuh wouldn’t have to work no more?”

She squinted at Leather and around at the other cowboys wonderingly.

“You know he said that, don’tcha, Ma?” asked Chet.

“Well, bless my soul! Where did ye ever get that strange idea?”

“That’s what he told me.”

Leather Kleig was serious enough to have been telling the truth.

“Nick Ralls told ye that, Leather?”

“Honest Injun, Ma.”

“Well, I dunno—” Ma looked vacantly around. “That’s news, so it is. I’ve niver heard—sure, you’re jokin’, now.”

“Ma, look here.” Wheezer put his hand on her shoulder. “You’ve been here ten years, workin’ hard. Did yuh ever think what Nick Ralls’ death would mean to you? This here lady boss ain’t noways human. She’d fire her own father. If she lets yuh out—what’ll become of yuh, Ma?”

Ma Coogan gasped slightly and shook her head.

“Sure, I—I dunno, boys. Why, the old ranch has been a home and I niver thought of bein’ fired. I—I’d hate to leave—here. But,” she lifted her head and smiled around at them, “sure, there’s no use of borryin’ a lot of trouble. The things ye worry the most about never happen.”

“Jist the same it’s wise to have your gun loaded,” observed Wheezer. “We was jist wonderin’ if yuh knowed what Nick Ralls intended to give yuh. We supposed that you knowed all about it, ’cause he told us.”

Ma Coogan looked straight into Wheezer’s eyes, and he turned away under her steady gaze.

“Ye’r’ a lovable liar, Wheezer,” she said softly, “but ye can’t fool old Ma Coogan. Sure, it’s nice of ye all, but ye know well that Nick Ralls niver had any such foolish ideas.”

Wheezer shuffled his feet nervously and shoved his hands deep into his pockets.

“Ma, we’re tryin’ to get a square-deal, thassall. If that fish-eyed lawyer asks yuh about it, would yuh mind just askin’ him if it ain’t in the will?”

“In the will?”

“Yeah. You don’t have to tell no lie, Ma. If he starts jawin’ around, which he will, just ask him that, will yuh?”

“Sure, I dunno what good it’ll do, but I’ll ask him.”

“Where’s the beautiful princess?” asked Wooden-shoe.

“Eatin’ in her own room. She’ll have her breakfast in bed, so she says—at tin o’clock. She asked me if you boys were fair samples of cowboys, and I told her that the NR niver hired samples.

“Thin,” Ma Coogan lowered her voice, “she asked me what a cattle-rustler was, and I told her it was a cowpuncher out of work. She said she’d have more respect, or there’d be four cattle-rustlers lookin’ for new positions. Sure, that’s what she said—‘positions’.”

Leather grinned and shook his head—

“She’s goin’ to be advised by the fish-eyed lawyer, Ma.”

“Thin, may God help the old ranch!” Ma exclaimed piously.

“It’ll sure need somethin’ from the outside,” said Wheezer sadly. “Don’t forget what you’ve got to say to him, Ma. It won’t be lyin’.”

Ma nodded and went back into the kitchen, while the four cowboys went back to the bunk-house.

“Suppose we can’t make that stick with the lawyer; what’ll we do?” asked Wooden-shoe.

“Do?” Leather Kleig flung one of his boots across the rough floor and wiggled his toes through a hole in his sock. “What’ll we do? By ——, we stole most of them NR cows for Nick Ralls, didn’t we? Then what in —— is goin’ to stop us from stealin’ ’em from the NR?”

“Not me,” Wooden-shoe shook his head quickly. “I’m a re-formed cattle-rustler, by gosh! From now on, I don’t rob nothin’ but stages and banks.”

“You goin’ to Broken Butte tomorrow, Leather?” asked Wheezer.

“What for? We ain’t even got enough money to play a game of seven-up.”

“Mebbyso we will have. Clay Hardy offered me fifty for that glass-eyed sorrel a week ago, but I wanted a hundred. Mebbe he’ll be wantin’ sixty dollars worth tomorrow, and if he does—that’s fifteen apiece.”

“I sabe a roulette system,” declared Wooden-shoe. “It’s a cinch. All yuh do——”

“Make it twenty apiece for three of us,” interrupted Leather. “That’s a better system than Wooden-shoe’s.”

The town of Broken Butte was a county seat, but, outside of that fact it had little to boast about. Perhaps there were a few more false-fronted buildings than in the average Western cow-town; perhaps it was a little hotter in Summer and colder in Winter; but it was still a weather-beaten, hitch-rack decorated, dusty-streeted cow-town.

There was the usual array of restaurants, where the inner man might be well appeased for two-bits. The fact that there were two livery-stables rather lifted Broken Butte out of the mediocre class, but its chief claim to distinction was the Shoshone Saloon, where wine, women and song brought surcease from range-land sorrows, and kept the cowboys broke but contented.

“Battler” Morgan owned the Shoshone, a pugnacious jaw, one cauliflower ear and a memory of the days when men fought with bare knuckles. He could throw a bottle almost as straight as a cowboy could shoot a gun—but not quite.

He had found this out to his sorrow, when he essayed to bounce a bottle off the head of Wheezer Bell. Wheezer had incurred Battler’s displeasure by slamming a bullet into the bottle, in mid-air. The bottle was coming toward Wheezer, but the .45 bullet caused it to sort of evaporate, and the neck of the bottle boomeranged into Battler’s front teeth.

Wheezer admitted that he shot at the bottle, which the rest of the NR gang knew to be a mistake, but it established Wheezer as a bad man to monkey with. Battler bought some “store” teeth and quit throwing bottles at gunmen.

Eph Williams owned an office on the main street, and he was climbing into a top-buggy when the four cowboys rode in from the NR ranch. Williams sighed with relief as he drove out of town.

He had no wish to meet these four men. He knew, to his sorrow, that they did not respect him in the least, and he secretly wished that they might be

hailed into court, charged with a serious offense.

For Eph Williams, in spite of the fact that he passed the collection plate at church, did not “Do unto others as you would have others do unto you.” These four men laughed at him, and he did not like that. He had often wondered why Nick Ralls hired these four men. One day he had asked Nick Ralls regarding them, and Nick Ralls had told him that it was none of his adjectived business.

The four cowboys watched Eph Williams drive out of town, and Chet wailed over the fact that they would not be at the ranch to greet him.

“We’d take off his wheels and make him walk home.”

“Yeah, and have him advise Cleopatra to fire us,” said Wheezer. “You ain’t got a —— bit of fi-ness.”

“That’s a nice word to call a friend,” said Chet accusingly. “You go and sell that wall-eyed cayuse to ‘Clay’ Hardy, professor.”

“Yeah, you do that,” agreed Leather. “But if yuh see that bat-headed Murtch, don’t antagonize him. He’s in cahoots with Williams.”

“Rope’s draggin’!” Wheezer whispered warningly.

Leather turned quickly and saw Murtch standing within five feet of him. He had come out of the Shoshone Saloon while they were talking. There was not the slightest doubt but what Murtch had heard what Leather Kleig had said, but his face told them nothing.

“All right, I’ll go and find Clay,” said Wheezer. Then to Murtch—

“Is Clay at the office?”

Clay Hardy was Murtch’s deputy; a vile-tempered, pasty-faced individual, who was reputed to be the best rifle-shot in the country, in spite of the fact that he was of the jerky, nervous type.

“I reckon he’s there,” replied Murtch softly, and walked past them, going across the street.

Wheezer led the sorrel down the street toward the sheriff’s office, while the other three cowboys went into the Shoshone, to wait for Wheezer to bring them funds enough for a little riotous living.

There was little warmth in Battler Morgan’s reception, but he did invite them to have a drink.

“What’sa matter with it?” asked Chet wonderingly.

“With what?” asked Battler.

“Yore liquor,” explained Chet. “You givin’ it away, kinda makes me wonder. How’s tricks, Battler?”

“All right,” growled Battler. He was not very quick witted. “Whatcha drinkin’?”

“I’ll smoke a see-gar,” stated Wooden-shoe. “Gift whisky hurts my stummick. Got any of them two-bit Flor de Loco Weeds? Yuh know what I mean—them dusty ones.”

“Never look a gift see-gar in the dust,” advised Leather, leaning across the bar and studying the labels on some dusty-looking case-goods.

“Well, name your drinks,” said Battler impatiently.

“W-h-i-t-e S-e-a-l,” spelled Leather. “What’s that—sody-water, Battler?”

“Champagne,” gruffly.

“I’ll take a chance on her,” nodded Leather.

“Yuh will? At ten dollars per bottle?”

“Well, ain’t we yore friends?” asked Chet. “Ten per bottle ain’t nothin’ between friends, ’specially when we’ve got a lady boss. Didja hear about it, Battler?”

Battler nodded.

“Murtch was tellin’ me. What you jaspers goin’ to do for a job?”

“Work for the NR,” replied Leather dryly, motioning for the bartender to open a bottle of champagne.

“Want me to open a bottle, Battler?”

The bartender wanted official sanction.

“No!” snapped Battler. “I ain’t wastin’ champagne on cowpunchers. Whisky’s good enough.”

“Not for me, it ain’t,” declared Leather, turning his back on the bar. “Battler won’t treat us right, ’cause he thinks we ain’t got nothin’ to spend in his danged place.”

“You fellers ain’t had no pay-day.”

Battler was so old in the liquor business that he did not mind admitting a lack of enthusiasm in treating men who were broke.

“Did yuh ever know us to have a pay-day?” asked Chet.

Battler thought it over and shook his head.

“No, I don’t think I have. You fellers has spent money, but I never heard yuh mention pay-day.”

“You remember that, will yuh?” asked Leather, but before Battler could ask a reason for remembering such a trifling thing, Wheezer came bustling in, kicking his spurred heels on the floor.

“Hookum cow!” he chortled, executing a very poor jig-step. “Nailed Clay for seventy dollars.”

He pulled the money out of his chaps pocket and piled it on the bar.

“Are you a sport?” queried Leather.

“Dang right!” exploded Wheezer. “Gimme action.”

Leather poked a ten-dollar gold piece out of the pile and shoved it across the bar.

“Give me that bottle of champagne.”

The bartender handed it across to him, while Wheezer leaned in close and peered at the dusty, long-necked bottle.

“Whazzat?” he asked curiously.

“This?” Leather patted the bottle. “This is the drink of kings, Wheezer.”

He took out his knife and inserted the blade under the wired top.

Wheezer glanced at the cash register and blinked at Leather.

“Ten dollars for a little bottle? My ——, what’s in it?”

Pwhop!

The cork hit Wheezer in the mouth, and most of the champagne struck him in the chest. Leather tried to hold his hand over the neck of the bottle, with the result that a stream of the liquor shot square into Wooden-shoe’s face. A shift of the hand shot the stream up into Leather’s face and he dropped the bottle on the floor.

Wheezer wiped his sleeve across his face and looked down at the bottle. He scooped up the rest of the money and stuffed it into his pocket.

“Yo’re all through playin’ king with my money,” he announced.

“You don’t open champagne like that,” explained the bartender chokingly. “You put a towel over——”

“Aw-w-w, ——!” snapped Leather. “I’ve opened lots of it.”

“Yeah, there was quite a lot in that bottle,” admitted Chet, feeling of his sticky shirt collar. “Kind of a magic bottle, ain’t they?”

“I’ll open a bottle,” announced Battler joyfully. “I’ll show yuh how it’s done.”

“After we’re gone, Battler—not now—” Wheezer was very emphatic —“I’ve swallowed a cork and I smell like I’d had a bath in hard cider. If yuh want to treat, I’ll take a see-gar.”

The other three nodded dismally and accepted an ancient cigar on the house, which they discarded after a puff or two in favor of a Durham cigaret. Wheezer relented and split his money among them, after which they wooed the goddess of chance in their own ways.

It was about three hours later that Eph Williams drove back to Broken Butte. It was only five miles to the NR ranch, which was far enough to give him a chance to cool his anger against the four cowboys.

He took his horse and buggy to the livery-stable and went back to his little office. Murtch had seen him, and wended his way to Williams’ office, where he found Williams in a vile mood. Murtch sat down and waited for Williams to cool down. These two understood each other very well.

“What’s the matter?” queried Murtch. “You act all het up, Eph.”

“Aw, ——!” exploded Eph, kicking a perfectly good law book off the corner of his desk, that he might have a resting-place for his feet.

“I just came in from the NR, and I find out that them four punchers are claiming that Ralls agreed to pay them once a year, and that the NR owes them four hundred and eighty dollars apiece.”

“That’s a —— of a thing to claim!” exclaimed Murtch indignantly. “Why, they can’t——”

“That ain’t all, Murtch. Miss Cleveland told me that Nick Ralls had promised old lady Coogan that he was going to settle enough money on her, after she had been there ten years, to keep her the rest of her life. And she’s been there just ten years.”

“Of all the —— fool things I ever heard!”

“Nick Ralls never kept any books. There ain’t a scratch of a pen to show how he run his ranch.”

“But they can’t git away with anythin’ like that,” protested Murtch. “There ain’t nobody runs a ranch that way, Eph.”

“Them four claim a total of nineteen hundred and twenty dollars,” said Eph thoughtfully. “That’s a —— of a lot of money, Murtch.”

“Ain’t she goin’ to fire ’em, Eph?”

“I suppose.”

Eph got to his feet and walked over to the door. Wheezer and Chet were coming across the street and their legs seemed a trifle unsecure. Eph opened the door and scowled at them.

“H’lo,” greeted Wheezer owlshly. “We’re after some legal advice.”

“Legal advice, eh?”

Williams squinted at them closely, but, in spite of the fact that they had been drinking, they seemed deadly serious.

Murtch came to the door and looked at the cowboys, who grinned widely at him.

“H’lo, sheriff!”

Wheezer cuffed his hat on to one side of his head and grinned wickedly.

“Whazza matter? You in trouble, too?”

“Not that anybody knows about,” retorted Murtch.

“Oh—” Wheezer’s lips formed a perfect O and he nodded wisely. “Not that anybody knows about, eh? Well, I s’pose it ain’t right to expose yoreself, but me and Chet are open and above-board in everythin’, ain’t we, Chettie?”

“Oh, very much so,” nodded Chet. “We don’t have no mustache to deceive the eye.”

Murtch grunted angrily and hooked his thumb over his belt above his holster. But this action did not frighten the two cowboys.

“He’s half-way home after his gun,” observed Chet wisely.

“Just what did you want to know?” asked Williams.

He knew that this talk was only leading up to trouble, and he wanted to avoid it if possible.

“Li’l point of law,” explained Wheezer.

“Me ’n Chet has had a argument about lawyers, don’tcha see?”

“What was the argument?”

“Well—” Wheezer cuffed his hat sideways again and grew very solemn —“well, this was the argument: I said that lawyers was predatory animals,

but Chet argues that there must be a open and a closed season on 'em. Me 'n Chet don't want to break no game laws."

Williams's lips tightened and his face flushed. He was fighting mad, but his better judgment told him to move carefully. Murtch swore under his breath and looked away, but Williams said nothing, as he turned slowly and went back into the office.

"There ain't no answer," said Chet softly.

"Betcha he's gone to look in a book. Lawyers always have to look into books, Chettie."

"My advice to you fellers would be—" began Murtch angrily, but Wheezer interrupted with—

"Nobody asked you for advice, Murtch."

"And nobody, if they've got any brains, ever will," added Chet.

"Is that so? Lemme tell you fellers somethin'. Broken Butte is tired of you four jaspers from the NR, and if you want to get away with a whole hide, yuh better move fast."

"My ——, you frighten me!" squeaked Wheezer. "My tonsils are weak and any sudden shock makes me choke all up."

"Aw, that's too bad," wailed Chet sadly. "Broken Butte is all through with us, Wheezer, don'tcha know it. Just like the song:

"Out in thish wide wor-r-rld alo-o-one,
Nothin' but sorrow I see-e-e-e;
I'm-m-m nobody's dar-r-rling,
Nobody car-r-r-res for me-e-e-e."

Chet's unmusical voice clung lovingly to the last notes and his eyes closed with ecstasy. Murtch snorted his indignation and walked swiftly away toward his office, both hands clenched around his cartridge-belt, while Wheezer sat down on the wooden sidewalk and shook with unholy mirth.

"What's so —— funny about it?" demanded Chet. "That's a sad song, ain't it? Somebody has to tell yuh when to cry. My, my! Yo're ignorant, cowboy."

Leather came out of the Shoshone and crossed the street to them. He was perfectly sober and his thin lips were tightly drawn, as if suppressing a grin.

"I tapped the old roulette for a hundred and fifty," he informed them. "And Wooden-shoe has corralled most of the chips in the stud-poker game. C'mon."

"Where yuh goin'?" demanded Wheezer.

"Clerk and Recorder's office. I'm goin' to take a look at old Nick Ralls' will."

"Why spoil a perfec' day? We jist insulted Williams and Murtch."

"We hope we did," amended Chet, "but I doubt it."

"All right," nodded Leather. "Go ahead and get us all fired."

The clerk's office was located at the north end of the town. Broken Butte had never been financially able to build a court house; so the county offices were badly scattered.

The clerk showed them the recorded will, and even volunteered to read it to them. It was short and to the point.

"Bein' in good health and sound of mind, eh?" grinned Leather, as the clerk finished reading. "That danged old gopher never was sound of mind. Leaves all his earthly possessions to Miss Jane Cleveland, his niece, who is his only known living relative."

"I understand that she has taken possession," remarked the clerk.

"Yo're danged right she has," grinned Wheezer. "Man, she's sure took right hold of the old ranch."

They left the clerk's office and started down the street. The stage was just driving up to the front of the general merchandise store, in which the post-office was located, and the three cowboys stopped to watch a newcomer disgorge himself from the interior of the dusty stage.

He was of medium height, slender of build and well dressed. His olive-tinted face was handsome, in spite of its lines of dissipation, and his tiny black mustache was waxed to needle-like points.

He dusted himself off with his hands, paid the driver his fare and watched him unpack two valises off the boot of the stage. He looked at the three cowboys and a flash of recognition crossed his face, but he turned

back to the driver, picked up his valises and went down the side-walk toward the Broken Butte hotel.

“You know that dude *hombre*, Leather?” asked Wheezer.

“Yeah. That’s the crookedest gambler unhung. I dunno who he is now, but when I knew him in Sunset City he was called ‘Spade’ Hollister.”

“Here comes Wooden-shoe,” said Chet. “He’s grinnin’; so I betcha he made a cleanup, too.”

“Hundred and eighty dollars,” announced Wooden-shoe joyfully. “Such an easy game to beat.”

“Let’s go home,” suggested Leather. “This town ain’t no ways friendly, and I’m kinda curious to know what the beautiful maiden has done to the NR since we left.”

“Go home—now!” Wooden-shoe was explosively surprised. “And me with a hundred and eighty?”

“Ain’t no ways fair to the heathen,” admitted Chet.

“All right, I’m goin’,” announced Leather, starting toward the hitch-rack.

“I’ll trail yore bet, Leather.”

Wheezer turned and followed Leather, but Chet and Wooden-shoe laughed derisively at such a foolish move, and went back to the Shoshone Saloon. That hundred and eighty dollars was burning a hole in Wooden-shoe’s pocket, and the fact that Broken Butte was hostile to him made not the slightest difference.

Leather and Wheezer went back to the ranch. Miss Cleveland was sitting on the ranch-house porch, as they rode past, and motioned for them to stop. They dismounted and came up to her.

“Mr. Williams was here this morning, and I spoke to him in regards to your yearly salaries,” she stated evenly. “He said that your claims were absurd. I quite agree with him. We have decided to pay you each forty dollars and dispense with your services, beginning tomorrow.

“Mr. Williams will be here in the morning and pay you off, I believe. I also spoke to him regarding Mrs. Coogan, and her claims, and he said that such a thing would be impossible.”

“Yeah, I see,” nodded Leather absently. “Williams is takin’ quite a lot upon himself, ain’t he, ma’am?”

“He is handling the legal matter for me.”

“You known Eph Williams long, ma’am?”

She shook her head.

“You need somethin’ beside legal advice, ma’am,” said Wheezer solemnly. “That fish-eyed shyster’ll git yuh into trouble, if yuh don’t watch out.”

“I am perfectly able to attend to my own affairs.”

Miss Cleveland’s tone chilled Wheezer, but he grinned widely.

Leather dropped his reins and leaned against the railing of the porch.

“Ma’am, I’d like to talk to yuh a little,” he said. “I ain’t sayin’ nothin’ for me and the boys. We don’t like this ranch—much. Losin’ a job don’t mean nothin’ to us, but I’d like to say somethin’ for Ma Coogan.

“Ma’s old, ma’am. Must be past sixty. It ain’t no ways easy for her to land another job, don’tcha see? She’s fine, Ma is. You won’t find nobody like her. She’s got to have a home. Old folks, like her, has got to have a home, don’tcha see, ma’am?”

Miss Cleveland studied Leather, as he talked, but he knew that she was not impressed with his argument.

“I am sorry,” she said, “but Mr. Williams will handle that part of it for me. I have no doubt but that Mrs. Coogan is a fine cook, but Mr. Williams has advised that I change the personnel of this ranch entirely and I am following his advice. Of course, you know, I am not running a charitable institution.”

“No, I didn’t reckon yuh was,” Leather sighed and picked up his reins.

For a moment he seemed downcast over her decision, but lifted his eyes and looked squarely into her face. Wheezer started instinctively forward as he saw the expression on Leather’s face.

Wheezer knew that Leather was at white heat. He had seen that same expression on Leather’s face before, and it meant that the devil within him had torn loose.

“Ma’am,” Leather’s tone was hoarse, as if he were suffering from a bad cold, “we ain’t askin’ for charity—ain’t askin’ nothin’ from you—now. You own the NR ranch, and you can do what yuh please with it. Lookin’ at you, I wonder what makes yore blood circulate. You ain’t got no heart.”

She sprang to her feet and faced him, and for a moment Wheezer thought she would attack him with her hands, but Leather's eyes did not waver and she stepped back, as if wondering.

"You coward!" she exclaimed. "To talk that way to a woman!"

"You are a woman," Leather nodded slowly. "But you are not a lady—not human."

"You get off this ranch!" Miss Cleveland bit her under-lip and pointed back to the road.

Leather shook his head.

"No. You own this ranch, but you don't know how much of it you don't own."

"What do you mean?"

"This is what I mean." Leather turned and pointed toward the rolling hills.

"There's a lot of NR cattle out in them hills, but you don't own many of them."

"Why—if they are NR brand—what do you mean?"

Leather laughed and walked off the porch to his horse, before he replied.

"Ask Eph Williams what I mean. If he don't know, I'll tell him. C'mon, Wheezer."

They led their horses down to the barn, while the girl looked after them, her face a mixture of emotions. Then she swore a good United States oath and went into the house.

It was nearly daylight the next morning when Chet Wells rode up to the NR corral-fence, tied his horse and hammered loudly on the bunk-house door. After making considerable racket he kicked the door open and went inside, where he war-whooped, like an Indian.

"Shut up and come to bed," said Leather sleepily. "Whatcha think this is around here?"

"Yee-o-o-o-ow!" yelped Chet. "I'm a coyote!"

"Dang right yuh are," agreed Wheezer. "Crawl into a hole before a he-human collects yore ears. Chet, you —— brayin' burro, shut up!"

But Chet would not shut up. He climbed up on Wheezer's chest and sat down, while he sang—

“I'm a tough ol' jasper and I'm lookin' for a fight;
I'll cut, shoot or rassel from mornin' until night
With a whang de oodle addy aye, addy aye.”

“Yeah, and you'll get it, too,” declared Leather angrily.

“Woosh!”

Wheezer managed to dump Chet on to the floor and sat up, gasping for breath.

“Are yuh all woke up?” queried Chet. “My gosh, you sure are heavy sleepers!”

“Where's Wooden-shoe?”

“Wooden-shoe is in jail.”

“In jail?”

“Yeah, in jail! Want me to yell it louder?”

“What for, Chet?”

“Talkin' too much.”

Leather slid out of bed and reached for the makings of a cigaret.

“Oh, he talked too much, eh?” said Wheezer. “If that was a crime, you'd 'a' been hung years ago, Chet. What did he talk about?”

“That wall-eyed bronc you sold to Clay Hardy. Yuh see—” Chet helped himself to Leather's tobacco and papers—“Clay and Murtch runs into me and Wooden-shoe, and they asks us to have a drink. We got to talkin' about that wall-eyed bronc, and Wooden-shoe, like a danged fool, tells 'em that he was the original owner. He says that you won it from him in a poker game out here.”

“Well, s'pose he did,” asked Wheezer. “What then?”

“Murtch asked Wooden-shoe who he got the bronc from and Wooden-shoe jist naturally can't say. Murtch says it's kinda funny, bein' as the bronc has got a D-Bar-D brand on its shoulder and no other marks.

“Well, Wooden-shoe's drinkin', which makes him foolish and he tells Murtch to go to ——. Then Murtch arrests him for stealin' a D-Bar-D horse.”

“And that’s a —— of a note!” exploded Wheezer.

“The D-Bar-D outfit is over in Foster County,” volunteered Chet dismally. “Murtch says that the brand never was put on very deep, and the hair covered it.”

“And if the D-Bar-D keeps a sale record—Wooden-shoe is in bad shape,” said Leather. “Dang the luck, I don’t know how we overlooked that brand. Cinch to burn on the two sides to that bar and make it a DAD brand.”

“Which won’t get Wooden-shoe out of jail now,” Chet reminded them sadly.

“We vented a lot of D-Bar-D’s, if I remember,” said Wheezer thoughtfully, “and if that outfit comes over to identify that wall-eyed bronc they’ll likely kinda look around for more.”

“Yuh can’t identify a vented brand,” said Chet.

“No, but yuh can get —— suspicious of an outfit with as many as the NR has on the range. Believe me, gents, I’m plumb ready to pull m’ freight.”

“What we need is a lawyer,” grinned Leather.

“I betcha we do,” Chet was serious.

“Might hire Eph Williams,” grinned Wheezer.

“Yeah, we might do worse,” nodded Leather. “He’s just crooked enough to defend a bunch of horse thieves and get away with it. I s’pose he’d want us to give him a bill of sale of the animals we stole.”

Chet kicked off his boots and stretched out on the bunk, where he proceeded to snore loudly. It was too early to dress; so Leather and Wheezer crawled back under their blankets again, and in a few minutes there was a trio of snores.

It was about eight o’clock when Leather and Wheezer got out of bed and slid into their clothes. Chet still snored loudly, but they did not wake him up. Wheezer went to the window and looked toward the ranch-house.

“Horse and buggy up there,” he announced. “Reckon the sweet lady’s guardian angel has arrived already.”

They finished dressing and went up toward the house. Eph Williams backed out of the door, carrying one end of a trunk, the other end of which

was being carried by a Chinaman.

Williams merely glanced at the two cowboys and went back into the house, followed by the Chinaman.

“Well, whatcha know about that?” grunted Wheezer.

They walked around to the back door, where they found Ma Coogan sitting on the wash-bench. Her old face was streaked with tears, and she was wearing a very old alpaca dress, which she had not worn for years, and beside her on the bench was a little old hat with a moth-eaten feather.

She looked up at them, but did not speak. Leather frowned and hitched at his belt as he and Wheezer looked at each other queerly.

“I—I’m goin’—somewhere,” said Ma Coogan painfully. “They got a Chinaman.”

She did not look up at them. Leather turned away and rubbed his chin violently. Then he whirled on Wheezer.

“Go down and wake up Chet and saddle the horses. We’ll have to bust that jail and get Wooden-shoe out and——”

Wheezer whirled to go back to the bunk-house, but Leather stopped him.

“Wait. That won’t do no good either. I was going to kill that —— lawyer, but that won’t help Ma.”

“Bless your hearts,” Ma looked up at them. “Sure, ye don’t need to worry about me.”

“No, I reckon not,” said Leather softly, “but we don’t want to have to eat Chink cookin’, Ma.”

“But the Lord love ye, we’re all fired.”

“That’s right. I’ll have to see that lawyer. Set still.”

Leather hurried around the house and Wheezer almost trod on his heels. Williams and Miss Cleveland were on the porch, and the Chinaman was putting the trunk into position to load it on to the back of the buggy.

“Whose trunk is that?” asked Leather.

“Mrs. Coogan’s,” said Williams defiantly.

Leather strode out to the Chinaman and pointed at the trunk.

“Roll it back to the porch, John.”

The Chinaman squinted at Leather and then at Williams.

“Didja hear what I said?” asked Leather.

“Yessah.”

The Chinaman tried to grin, but it was a weak effort.

“Then roll it back like I told yuh to do.”

“Just a moment.”

Williams grew very indignant and came down the steps.

“Let that trunk alone.”

“Roll it over to the porch, John,” ordered Leather. And then to Williams:

“Yo’re on thin ice, pardner. Keep out of the argument.”

The Chinaman rolled the trunk back to the porch.

“Now, get into that buggy,” ordered Leather, and the Chinaman lost no time in obeying. He had lived long in the range-country and knew better than to refuse an armed cowboy.

“You are just wasting your breath,” stated Williams with a weak smile.

“Being armed, you have the advantage—for the moment.”

With a quick twist of his wrist, Leather flipped the gun from his holster and tossed it aside.

“Now, whatcha say?” he asked softly.

“My dear man, there is no use of a quarrel.”

Williams spread his hands and shrugged his shoulders. He tried to be friendly, but it was all lost on Leather.

“Yo’re seven-eighths coyote and—no, I won’t say that either. There’s two skunks in Broken Butte, and yo’re both of ’em.”

“You seem determined to quarrel with me, I see,” said Williams sadly. “I am only doing my duty, Kleig.”

“Yeah?”

Leather considered Williams for a space of time and nodded slowly.

“I reckon yo’re all right, Williams. I never trust a man that’ll back down. Shake, will yuh?”

Leather shoved out his hand, and Williams, a look of wonder on his face, shook hands solemnly with him. Wheezer swallowed with great difficulty and kicked himself on the ankle to see if he was asleep. Miss Cleveland’s face expressed astonishment, and even the Chinaman’s expressionless face changed its placid contour for a moment.

“I want to talk with yuh kinda private,” said Leather softly. “Mebbe we better go down to the bunk-house, eh? C’mon, Wheezer.”

Williams swallowed painfully, wonderingly and looked at Miss Cleveland, but followed behind them to the bunk-house steps, where they sat down.

“I ain’t never hired a lawyer before,” stated Leather, “and I dunno just how to go about tellin’ him things. Is it a fact that what yuh tell a lawyer is kinda—uh——”

“I think I know what you mean,” nodded Williams. “Whatever you tell me will be sacred.”

“Yeah, that’s the word I was huntin’ for,” grinned Leather. “Yo’re educated, Williams, and I sure like to talk to educated folks.”

Wheezer choked over his cigaret and dug his heels into the dirt. He wanted to yell out loud. Williams accepted the compliment as his just due.

“It better be sacred,” said Leather, “or four good punchers will swell the census of the penitentiary.”

Williams pricked up his ears, but tried to appear unconcerned.

Leather glanced sideways at him, but Williams was rubbing his chin thoughtfully and trying to control his elation. He had been insulted many times by these four wild-riding cowpunchers, and he was more than willing to have them bare their guilty secrets.

“I ain’t doin’ this so much for us as I am for the lady,” explained Leather slowly. “She thinks she inherited somethin’, pardner.”

“Ahem-m-m!”

Williams cleared his throat raspingly, but waited for Leather to continue.

“It dates back quite a while,” continued Leather. “Yuh see, old Nick Ralls wasn’t no saint. The NR wasn’t no payin’ proposition and old Nick was just about at the *hondo* end of his rope when we showed up.

“We kinda made him a proposition. It’s hard for a cattle-rustler to dispose of stock these days, don’tcha know it?”

“I—er—shouldn’t be surprized,” nodded Williams.

“Anyway,” continued Leather, “here’s what was done. The four of us misbranded every danged critter we could find. We worked plumb over into

Foster County. 'Course we didn't steal a lot of Broken Butte cows, but there's a few.

"We branded 'em with the NR iron, and Nick Ralls was to do the sellin'. His idea was to make the old NR look like a regular cow-ranch and sell out the whole works. Then he was to split the money; *sabe?*"

Williams squinted painfully at Leather. Somehow he could hardly believe that statement, and wondered where the joke came in. But Leather's face was serious.

"You—you are not joking?" asked Williams.

"Don'tcha believe it. I ain't tryin' to excuse us. The NR owes us plenty of money, which we've got to collect, but I just wanted yuh to know how we stand, and how the lady—well, yuh can see what she inherited."

"Yes, yes!" Williams seemed to be doing a lot of fast thinking. "Do you think there is any danger of an investigation? Is there—nobody suspects you, do they?"

"Here's the point." Leather tapped Williams on the shoulder and lowered his voice. "Yesterday we sold a horse to Clay Hardy. We didn't know it, but that horse had a D-Bar-D brand on its shoulder. Murtch arrested Wooden-shoe Van Dorn and threwed him in jail.

"Murtch is goin' to send word to the D-Bar-D outfit, over in Foster County, and find out how it comes that we had that horse." Leather pointed out toward the hills and laughed grimly. "Them hills are full of D-Bar-D cows, with the brands vented and the NR run on.

"If that outfit comes over here to see about that wall-eyed bronc, they'll start lookin' for other stock they've lost, don'tcha see?"

"That's right. But you vented the brands——"

"Yeah, and there'll be a —— of a lot for us to explain if they find out about all them vented brands. It'll look kinda bad, don't yuh think?"

Williams got to his feet.

"You sit tight, all of you," he ordered. "I'll stop Murtch, if it isn't too late."

He hurried toward the buggy, sprang in beside the Chinaman and whirled the horse around. Miss Cleveland called to him, but he put whip to horse and turned out of the ranch-house gate on two wheels.

Leather watched him disappear in a cloud of dust and then looked wonderingly at Wheezer.

“He—he’s in a hurry,” observed Wheezer.

Leather looked back up the road and nodded slowly, as a smile creased his thin features.

“Whatcha want to—” began Wheezer, but Leather stopped him.

“Don’t talk to me, Wheezer! Lemme think, will yuh? I’ve got an idea, but some of the parts are missin’.”

Chet Wells opened the door behind them and blinked into the sunlight.

“Leather hired Williams for our lawyer, Chet,” said Wheezer solemnly.

“Yeah, I heard it,” nodded Chet. “I heard old fish-eye’s voice; so I glued m’ ear to the door. Whatcha tryin’ to do—put us in the penitentiary, Leather?”

“He won’t talk to yuh,” stated Wheezer. “He’s thinkin’, Chet.”

“She’s about time he done a little thinkin’. He sure didn’t do any thinkin’ when he told our shame to that danged lawyer.”

Leather got to his feet and went to the house. Ma Coogan was still sitting on the wash-bench, waiting for Williams to take her away. She looked up at him and he grinned softly.

“Ma, you take off that dress,” he ordered kindly. “You can’t cook no breakfast, all dressed up thataway.”

“Cook breakfast? The Lord love ye, I’m——”

“Williams has gone back with his Chinaman, Ma. You go right back and fry us a flock of eggs. Mebbe there ain’t goin’ to be no change.”

“Do ye mean that, boy?” Ma got to her feet and put a trembling hand on his arm. “Ye’re not jokin’, are ye?”

Leather shook his head.

“No, I’m not, Ma. You’re still the chief cook of the NR ranch. The lawyer feels kinda different than he did a while ago.”

“Sure, I dunno what to say.” The old lady’s eyes sparkled with happiness as she looked around and picked up her old hat. “It’s like wakin’ from a bad dream, so it is. God is good to me, Leather Kleig. I’m goin’ to fry thim eggs—now.”

She stopped in the doorway and looked back at him, the tears running down her face, but went on into her beloved kitchen. Leather blinked uncertainly and shoved down on his cartridge-belt, after which he went around the house and picked up the six-shooter he had discarded.

Jane Cleveland was standing on the porch and she looked curiously at him. He grinned at her and gazed down the road.

“The lawyer went away in a hurry,” he observed. “I reckon I better carry Ma’s trunk back into her room.”

“I do not understand it,” she said.

“Neither do I,” he admitted, swinging the trunk back on to the porch, “but I reckon it’ll be all right, ma’am.”

He deposited the trunk in Ma Coogan’s little room and came back to the porch, but Jane Cleveland had gone to her room.

It was about three hours later that Wooden-shoe rode into the ranch and dismounted at the bunk-house. He was grinning widely.

“Bust out?” queried Chet.

“Huh!” Wooden-shoe grinned knowingly. “Much obliged to yuh. That sheriff was mad enough to eat hay. How did you fellers manage to sneak in and vent that brand last night?”

“Eh?” grunted Wheezer. “Whatcha mean?”

“Aw-w-w!”

Wooden-shoe turned the horse around and showed them the left shoulder of the animal, where a hot iron had completely destroyed any possibility of ever deciphering the original brand.

“That’s a good joke,” grinned Wooden-shoe. “Murtch was awful sore. He said it was a —— good thing that he hadn’t sent word to the D-Bar-D. He knows who done it, but he can’t prove it, and he knows that, too.”

Chet and Wheezer looked inquiringly at Leather, but he merely grinned and nodded.

“Well, what’s the answer?” queried Chet wonderingly.

“Our lawyer is workin’,” Leather said with a chuckle.

“Kinda looks like it,” admitted Wheezer. “But lawyers come pretty high, don’t they? How are we goin’ to pay him, Leather?”

“I dunno—yet.”

That afternoon the four cowpunchers saddled their horses and headed for Broken Butte. There was nothing for them to do at the ranch—and they still had money left.

Miss Cleveland had spent most of the day in the shade of the porch, reading, while Ma Coogan lifted her quavering voice in song in the kitchen.

Half-way to town they met Eph Williams, driving toward the ranch. He drew up his horse and smiled, or rather smirked at them.

“You sure got into action real fast,” said Leather, “and we’re sure much obliged to yuh, Williams.”

“Yes, I think it was well handled, Kleig. Now, my advice to all of you would be to leave this country as soon as possible. In defense of my client I shall bend every effort to protect what is legally her property.

“As far as your salary claims are concerned, I am afraid they can not be met. Miss Cleveland has no money, and Nick Ralls left nothing but property, which would be hard to dispose of right away.”

“Yeah, that’s right, I reckon,” nodded Leather, “but it ain’t hardly fair to us. I’ll tell yuh what we might do: We might each take twenty-five head of beef steers and sell ’em. They’re worth about twenty dollars on the hoof right now.”

“Well—” Williams smiled weakly—“I’d hardly advise that either.”

“How many would we take for Ma’s share?” queried Chet seriously.

“Hard to tell.” Leather rubbed his chin thoughtfully. “Ranch cooks gets about fifty per month, and if yuh figure that out for ten years and divide it by twenty—it would be quite a few cows.”

“Be about three hundred head,” said Chet. “We’ll take four hundred head of NR steers and call it square.”

Williams shook his head quickly.

“No, that would not be hardly fair to Miss Cleveland. She had nothing to do with this matter, and all claims against the estate must be in a form that the court would consider. Verbal agreements are, I am sure, something that would hardly be considered in a court of law.”

“Well, we’ll kinda hang around,” stated Leather. “Yuh never can tell what might happen. I think that old Nick was plumb loco when he wrote

that will.”

“Not at all, Kleig; he was perfectly sane—perfectly.”

“I dunno how he got thataway,” grinned Wheezer. “He sure was always loco before.”

They rode on toward town, and Williams went on toward the NR. Leather was very thoughtful. There was the germ of an idea in his mind—a far-fetched feeling that it was a bright idea, and he grinned softly under the brim of his sombrero.

There was a big poker game in progress in the Shoshone when they came in. Battler Morgan, “King” Cole, a big horse raiser from the south end of the range, Jim Kelly, owner of the general merchandise store, Clay Hardy and Spade Hollister.

A number of men were watching the play, among them being Murtch. He scowled at the four cowpunchers, and moved around to the far side of the table. Spade Hollister glanced up at Leather, who was standing almost behind Clay Hardy, and half-nodded in recognition. Leather watched Spade closely—especially when he was dealing. His long, slender fingers dealt with baffling speed, but there was little chance for crooked play.

“Deal ’em a little slower, if yuh don’t mind.”

Clay Hardy was losing and inclined to be nasty about it.

“I didn’t learn poker in a hay-loft,” said Spade softly, and King Cole laughed heartily.

Clay Hardy scowled, as he picked up his hand, but did not reply. Leather glanced down at Hardy and noticed that Hardy’s holster was empty. A closer inspection showed that Mr. Hardy had the gun on his lap.

Leather’s lips tightened perceptibly. It looked to him as if Hardy was anticipating trouble. Leather glanced at Murtch who had moved from behind Hollister and was almost directly behind King Cole.

Clay lost that pot and swore softly at his luck. Spade glanced keenly at Hardy and flashed a look at Murtch.

“Spade’s the one Clay’s watchin’,” observed Leather to himself, “and Spade knows it.”

Battler Morgan dealt and the pot was passed. Hardy failed to deal openers and the deal passed to Kelly. On Kelly’s deal, Cole passed. Spade

deliberated, but passed, and Battler opened moderately.

Hardy tilted the pot heavily, which caused Cole and Kelly to pass, but Spade called the raise and boosted the pot a hundred dollars. Battler passed and Hardy called. It took all of his chips, except one small stack of whites.

Leather watched the draw closely. Hardy tossed his discards on to the table, spinning them just a trifle too far, and two of them slid in front of Hollister, who brushed them aside.

Spade drew one card and Hardy drew three. He peered at the corners of his cards and his right hand drew off the table and dropped to his lap. Spade passed. For a moment Clay Hardy's eyes squinted grimly at Spade and his lips tightened. Then—

“Pass,” he said softly.

Spade flipped his cards over. He had three kings and a pair of nines. Hardy leaned across and looked at them. Then he exposed his hand.

“Aces and sevens,” muttered Battler.

“Yeah, aces and sevens,” said Hardy, “and they’d ’a’ been good, if that—— tin-horn gambler hadn’t stole the king I discarded.”

For an instant there was a dead silence. Then Spade jerked back in his chair. Quick as a flash, Clay Hardy's hand came up over the table-top, gripping a revolver, but before he could level it at Hollister, Leather had flung himself across Hardy, blocking him and tearing the gun out of his hand.

Then he upset Hardy, who went sprawling and cursing against the corner of the wall.

Leather staggered sidewise, caught his balance and faced the crowd. The players had got to their feet and were looking at Hardy, who was swearing vengeance and getting to his feet.

“Lucky thing yuh blocked him, Kleig,” said King Cole. “He sure gets his gun quick.”

Leather was facing Hardy now, and Hardy was frothing with anger, but mindful of the gun which Leather was holding against his ribs.

“Yeah, he gets a gun quick,” smiled Leather, “but he got it off his lap—not out of his holster.”

“He stole my discard!” panted Hardy. “I tell yuh——”

“You’re a liar,” said Leather softly. “I watched him. You discarded into him to get an excuse to kill him. You wasn’t goin’ to give him an even break.”

“What’s that to you, you horse-thief?”

Clay Hardy spat out the question loud enough for every one in the place to hear. Leather did not move for a moment. He seemed to be deliberating just what to do. Then he handed King Cole the gun he had taken from Hardy.

“Put that in his holster,” he said softly.

Cole looked curiously at him, but stepped over and dropped the gun into Hardy’s holster. Hardy’s hands were hanging loosely at his sides, and he was hunched forward staring at Leather, who had lifted his right hand waist-high above the butt of his holstered-gun.

“Hardy,” Leather’s voice was low pitched, “you’re a dirty coyote pup. You spoke out of turn just now, and I’m givin’ yuh a chance to see if you’ve got guts enough to reach for a gun. I’m waitin’.”

Hardy’s face looked pinched and white now, and he was breathing fast. His eyes flashed around, as though wanting some one to interfere. Then his eyes came back to Leather Kleig and his knees quivered.

Then his hand came slowly up to his mouth and the back of it trembled across his dry lips. He turned and went out of the door, striking his shoulder against the side, like a drunken man who is not sure of his step.

“He’s whipped,” stated King Cole hoarsely. “Didja ever see a man get scared thataway? My ——, it sure was worth seein’.”

“Yeah, he sure turned yaller,” agreed Battler, turning back to his chair. “I s’pose that busts up a perfectly good game.”

Murtch had nothing to say. Spade Hollister seemed to watch him closely, but Murtch did not look toward him. Battler cashed in the chips and invited every one to have a drink, but Murtch went out without accepting the invitation.

Spade Hollister came over to Leather and stood beside him at the bar.

“Kleig, I’m much obliged to you,” he said.

“Tha’sall right,” said Leather gruffly. “I wouldn’t ’a’ said a word, if you’d ’a’ stole that king.”

Spade looked curiously at him and back to the bartender, who was taking their order. Wheezer, Chet and Wooden-shoe were at the bar, chuckling among themselves over what had just happened.

They drank and moved away from the bar. Hollister looked at Leather, who started away from the bar. He half-smiled and stepped over beside him.

“Kleig, if I can ever help yuh in any way—just speak the word.”

Leather turned and looked keenly at him.

“Spade Hollister, I’d ’a’ done that for any man. I’m no angel, but I’d have to hate —— out of a man to stand by and see him murdered. I s’pose you know what it was all about, don’tcha? Then yuh know who to look out for. If I need yuh—I’ll yelp.”

“And I’ll come,” nodded Spade as he turned and walked over to a roulette lay-out.

The other three cowboys edged up to Leather and they grouped together near the door.

“Cowboy, yuh sure work fast,” applauded Wheezer, slapping Leather on the shoulder. “And yuh sure put the fear of —— into Clay Hardy.”

“Yeah, but look out for him,” cautioned Wooden-shoe. “He’s whipped, but he ain’t dead. That gambler sure owes you a lot. In another second he’d have been plugged.”

“And what for?” questioned Wheezer. “He’s a plumb stranger here, ain’t he? What’s Clay Hardy gunnin’ at a stranger for, I wonder?”

Leather shook his head and turned to King Cole, who came up to him. Cole grinned and slapped Leather on the shoulder.

“Kleig, I hear that you’ve got a female boss out at the NR. It can’t be done. If you fellers need a new job, come down to the KC horse outfit and go to work. It’s the same old forty-a-month and eats.”

Leather smiled and shook his head.

“Yuh heard Clay Hardy call me a horse-thief, didn’t yuh Cole?”

“Yeah, and yuh never denied it. Yuh never did steal many horses, did yuh?”

“Half a dozen, mebbe.”

“Pshaw, that don’t make yuh a horse-thief. Some folks draws the line too close.”

Cole laughed at his own wit and went to the door, where he turned.

“That offer holds good. Come any old time.”

“Thank yuh, Cole,” grinned Leather.

“Well, that’s a job, if we need it,” said Chet.

“If we need it,” nodded Leather.

The cowboys went back to the games, but Leather did not play. He took a seat against the wall, where he tilted back and appeared to be half-asleep. Once he counted his money carefully and stowed it away in the watch-pocket of his overalls.

There was no sign of Murtch nor Hardy. The afternoon wore away, and the oil chandeliers of the Shoshone were lighted. It was Saturday night and there was a heavy influx of cowboys.

The three-piece orchestra began screeching, and the dance-hall girls were out in force, mingling with the men. Wheezer, Chet and Wooden-shoe were firmly implanted in different games; so Leather crossed the street alone to a restaurant. The waiter was the same Chinese that Williams had brought to the ranch, and he grinned in a friendly manner at Leather.

“No *sabe*,” he told Leather seriously. “Catchum job quick, lose ’m allesame.”

“Yuh didn’t last long, that’s a fact, John.”

“No last. Man swear alletime. Velly mad, I t’ink. W’at you like eat, eh?”

“What did he say about us, John?”

“No talk ’bout you—talk ’bout God. Yo’ *sabe*?”

“Religious, eh?”

“’Ligious? Yo’ mean—same like wo’ship?”

“Yeah, like worship, John.”

The Chinaman grinned and shook his head.

“No like. Yo’ wan’ soup?”

Leather finished his meal and went outside. He was a trifle cautious, for fear that Clay Hardy might try to ambush him. He knew that Clay would welcome a chance to get even for what had happened in the Shoshone, but he was sure that Clay would never face him in the light.

He strolled up the street and was going past the Broken Butte hotel, but stopped and stared in the window. Then he whirled around and went

quickly inside. Ma Coogan was sitting in one of the hotel chairs against the wall, her hands folded in her lap.

She looked up as he came in and a smile wreathed her wrinkled old face.

“Sure I’ve been wonderin’ if I’d see you,” she said.

“Well, what are you doin’ here, Ma?” he demanded.

“I was brought here by the lawyer. Ah! I think it’s no use, Leather. He came this afternoon and had a long talk with Miss Cleveland, and thin—” Ma Coogan stopped and shook her head sadly—“and thin they loaded my trunk in the back of the buggy and made me come along.”

“I see.” Leather’s face hardened and he squinted thoughtfully. “He waited until we were gone. Have you got a room here, Ma?”

She shook her head.

“Leather, I have no money. Ye well know that Nick Ralls only gave me a home and——”

Leather turned and strode over to the desk.

“Give this lady a room,” he demanded. “She’s got a trunk somewhere. Here—” He tossed a twenty dollar gold piece on the desk—“that’s enough for now. When that’s gone, I’ve got more.”

“Yeah, sure, I’ll fix her up,” said the frowsy-looking clerk. “Dollar a day’s the best we’ve got.”

Leather went back to Ma and handed her another twenty.

“Yuh got to eat, Ma. This feller’ll fix yuh up for a room. Now don’tcha worry about anythin’.”

He patted her on the shoulder and escaped out of the door before she fully realized what he had done.

“Yo’re a —— of a gunman, ain’tcha!” Murtch snorted angrily, but it had little effect on Clay Hardy, who sat hunched up in one of their office chairs, chewing tobacco violently. He only increased his mastications per minute.

Murtch jerked a chair into position and flopped down, facing Hardy.

“Everythin’ worked wrong,” complained Hardy nervously. “If that —— Kleig hadn’t come in when he did and put the whole thing into a jam.”

“Yuh had an even break with him.”

“Yeah—with him.”

“Scared of him, eh?”

“I ain’t no crazy suicide, Murtch.”

“You was plumb scared to breathe, Clay.”

“Uh-huh. You’d ’a’ been the same. He’s got under yore hide, and yuh never call him for it, Murtch. How did I know that Kleig was goin’ to block me?”

“You was a fool to have that gun in your lap.”

“Yeah,” nodded Clay seriously, “I was a fool to have a gun a-tall. I ought to pack a doughnut.”

Murtch laughed hoarsely.

“Well, I reckon it kinda spoils our plans, but there’s more than one way to skin a cat. We’ve got the goods on that NR gang, if we want to use it.”

“Yo’re the boss, Murtch. All I ask is that yuh don’t get me into no mix-up with ’em. They don’t use no judgment. Law and order don’t mean nothin’ to that bunch, and a sheriff’s star looks like a bulls-eye to them.”

“I’d hate to hear what folks will say about you, after the way yuh acted in front of Kleig.”

“I’d a —— sight rather be able to hear ’em say I backed down than to not hear ’em say I was crazy to try to beat Kleig on the draw.”

“Well, there might be somethin’ to that. Let’s go and see what Williams has got to say.”

They locked up the office and went up the street to Williams’ place. He had but lately arrived from the ranch and greeted them with a grin.

“I brought the old woman down with me,” he explained. “So that’s that much done. I’ll take the Chink out there again in the morning. What did you do on that other proposition?”

Briefly, but with sundry oaths, Murtch told of what had happened in the Shoshone. Hardy made no comments. Williams scowled deeply and tapped on the table-top with his finger-tips.

“What do yuh advise?” asked Murtch.

“Sitting tight. There has been too many mistakes. There will be a howl raised when they find that the old woman has been discharged. Miss

Cleveland did not want to stay out there alone, but I assured her that everything would be all right.”

“Well, I hope yo’re right,” nodded Murtch getting to his feet. “If that bunch get drunk, yuh never can tell what they’ll do. They think a lot of the old woman.”

“Pshaw! What does a horse-thief care about an old woman? They’ve got enough to look after, if they keep themselves out of jail.”

“All right. We’ll figger things out in the mornin’. Come on, Clay.”

They went out and closed the door. Williams lighted a frayed cigar and opened his safe, which was set into the wall behind his desk. It was an old-fashioned safe, which opened with a key.

He took out a mass of papers and looked them over in the light of his lamp. For a long time he studied them and then replaced them in the safe, after which he pocketed the key.

As he turned down the lamp, preparatory to blowing it out, there came a knock on the door. He hesitated for a moment and seemed about to call out, but changed his mind and went to the door. He turned the knob and looked outside.

There was no one in sight. He leaned out and glanced down the street. Then something crashed down upon his head and he fell backward into the room.

It was about three o’clock in the morning when Wheezer, Chet and Wooden-shoe decided to go back to the ranch. None of them had seen Leather, and, as his horse was missing from the hitch-rack, they decided that he had preceded them to the NR.

The gods of the green cloth had not been good to the trio, and there was little merriment within them as they left Broken Butte.

“I’m as clean as the dew,” said Wheezer sadly. “I spent m’ substance in tryin’ t’ make two-pair beat three of a kind.”

“Yuh ought to play roulette,” observed Wooden-shoe. “Get yuh a little system, that’s all yuh need.”

“How much you got left?” demanded Chet.

“I still got my system left—and a four-bit piece.”

“I sure hope that Leather’s got some money left,” said Chet. “My pesos has all gone where the woodbine twineth and the pelican trilleth to its mate.”

They unsaddled their horses and went up to the bunk-house door. It was bright moonlight, almost as light as day, and their eyes beheld a great and varied assortment of things piled on the steps.

They looked the things over carefully and grunted their amazement.

“Looks like somebody done moved us out,” observed Wheezer. “What’s on the door?”

He climbed over the stuff and studied a square of white paper which was tacked on the door. He scratched a match and read the message aloud.

“Notice. Any one entering this building without my permission will be prosecuted to the full extent of the law.”

Wheezer whistled softly and looked back at them.

“And she’s signed by Miss Jane Cleveland, owner of the NR ranch.”

“Door locked?” asked Chet.

“Locked ——! It’s nailed tight.”

“Well,” observed Wooden-shoe optimistically, “it’s a good thing that it ain’t Winter and zero weather.”

“That’s a —— of a thing to be joyful about.”

Wheezer climbed back and sat down on a pile of blankets.

“I wonder where Leather is.”

“Prob’ly asleep in the barn,” said Chet. “That —— lawyer sure foxed us, didn’t he? That whippoorwill ain’t workin’ for us, that’s a cinch, and I’m goin’ to curry him to the queen’s taste. Yessir, I’m goin’ to hit him so hard that he’ll have a permanent part in his hair.”

“I hope,” said Wooden-shoe, “he dies before his time comes.”

“Let’s go down to the barn and join Leather in the hay,” suggested Wheezer. “Mebbe there ain’t no notice on the hay-loft.”

They filed down to the big barn and crawled into the loft, which still contained a ton or so of hay, but Leather was not there.

“Prob’ly never left town,” said Wheezer as he burrowed into the hay. “Gosh dang it, we’ll wake up full of fox-tail, I betcha.”

He was facing the opening of the loft, a doorless opening, about six-feet square, which gave him a view of the ranch-house yard and the big gate. The moon was partly obscured for a few minutes, which made objects rather hazy, but he saw a horseman coming toward the gate, traveling slowly.

“Here comes Leather,” he stated. “Let him see the notice, et cettery, and then listen to him cuss.”

The others shifted their positions to watch him. He was almost under the arch of the gate, when a streak of orange-colored flame seemed to spurt up at him from a brush-tangle just beyond, and the thud of a revolver shot broke the stillness.

The boys in the loft were unable to see just what did happen, but the rider was shooting now. Another spurt of flame came from the tangle. Three times the rider’s gun spat fire, the reports mingling with those from the brush.

“My ——, what’s goin’ on?” gasped Wheezer, almost falling out of the loft opening.

“There he goes!” exclaimed Chet.

The rider had turned and was riding rapidly away, the sound of the galloping horse dying away in the distance.

They tumbled out of the loft and raced toward the gate, each man carrying a gun in his hand. Out through the gate they ran and stopped in the road.

“Over here!” panted Wheezer. “He was shootin’ from that bunch of— look out! There he is.”

A man was lying sprawled on his face in the tangle, and the moonlight glinted on his revolver, which was lying on the ground near him. They did not need to turn him over to see it was Clay Hardy.

“Whatcha know?” panted Chet. “The dirty bushwhacker!”

“Yeah, he shot first,” agreed Wheezer. “I seen him shoot first. Wonder if he’s dead.”

“Feel of his heart,” said Wooden-shoe. “If it ain’t beatin’, he’s dead.”

“It sure takes brains to know that!” grunted Chet.

Wheezer turned him over and felt of his heart. It was beating jerkily.

“He ain’t dead—yet. What’ll we do with him?”

“Take him to a doctor,” suggested Wooden-shoe.

“And go to the pen for shootin’ him?” queried Chet.

“He got cultivated on the head,” stated Wheezer. “A bullet sure danced a jig on his noodle, but I don’t reckon it went through. Was that Leather?”

“Looks like it might ’a’ been. Him and Hardy had a run-in, and I’ll betcha Hardy sneaked out here and laid for him. He never budged when we came through.”

Chet walked back down the road, where a number of cottonwoods made a black blotch against the sky. Just to the left of them grew a tangle of stunted willows.

“Here’s his horse!” called Chet, and went over into the willows after it.

They could see the outlines of the ranch-house, but the shooting had not caused any one to light a lamp nor come to investigate.

“I’ll betcha that Cleopatra’s scared stiff,” said Wheezer.

“Cleopatra ain’t got a —— thing on me if she is,” declared Wooden-shoe. “I’m scared, too, y’betcha.”

Chet came back with the saddled horse and they boosted Clay Hardy aboard.

“We’ve got to have ropes to hold him on with,” said Chet, as they tried to balance the swaying figure. “We’ll take him over to the barn and rope him on good, and then we’ll saddle up and take him to town.”

It took Eph Williams a long time to wake up from the smash on his head. He had been hit a solid clip and things were rather hazy in his mind for some time. It cost him considerable pain to crawl over to his chair, where he sat and recuperated.

He was not in the best physical condition and he cursed himself weakly, while he wondered what had happened to him. A bump the size of an egg on his head attested to the fact that something had hit him—and hit him hard.

Gradually he recovered sufficiently to try to analyze what had really occurred. He knew now that some one had knocked him down. Who it was and why, he did not know. He examined the contents of his pockets, but everything was intact. The safe was locked, the papers on his desk all in place.

“Must have been a personal matter,” he observed thankfully, but was unable to blame any certain person. A lawyer of his type makes many enemies.

He secured some water and bathed his head carefully, after which he took a bottle of whisky from his desk and indulged freely. It was nearly daylight now. He looked at his watch, tried to put his hat on over the knob on his head, but decided it was too painful; so he went outside bare-headed, locked his office and went down to see Murtch.

Murtch was not ready to get out of bed, and he swore peevishly at Williams, who persisted on hammering on the front door of the office. Finally Murtch came and opened the door.

“Now, what in —— do you want?”

“Somebody hit me on the head,” explained Williams.

“Yeah?” Murtch was very sarcastic.

“Prob’ly didn’t want to hurt yuh, so they hit yuh on the head.”

“Must have had a gun or something,” said Williams, feeling tenderly of his recently acquired swelling.

“What’s the joke?”

“No joke,” Williams shook his head. “I tell you, I got knocked down in the doorway of my own office. Look at my head.”

Murtch examined the swelling and his demeanor changed.

“Come on inside.”

Murtch lighted a lamp and drew on his pants and boots.

“Now, who hit yuh, Eph?”

“I don’t know. A while after you left I heard some one knock. I went to the door, stuck my head outside—and got hit. I tell you, it made me sick.”

“Huh!”

Murtch drew out his watch and glanced at it.

“You must ’a’ been knocked out quite a while.”

“Yes, I think so. I didn’t come down here right away, because I was too sick. I haven’t the slightest idea of why it was done. I was not robbed and there is nothing missing from my office.”

“That’s danged queer,” observed Murtch. “Yo’re sure they didn’t take anythin’?”

“Not a thing. Where is Clay Hardy?”

“I dunno. He got sore at me and went away. Mebbe I talked a little too tough to suit him.”

Williams rubbed his sore head and thought deeply.

“Those cowpunchers have likely gone back to the ranch,” he said thoughtfully, “and I’ve promised to bring that Chinaman out there this morning, but I don’t feel like it.”

“I’ll take him out,” offered Murtch.

“You will? Well—” thoughtfully—“perhaps that would be better. You see, I nailed up the bunk-house door, after I moved out all their things, and put a trespass notice on the door.”

“And yuh think it would be better, eh? No wonder yuh don’t want to go out there. Moved ’em out and nailed the door, eh?”

“Miss Cleveland suggested it.”

“The —— she did! I thought you was supposed to be her adviser.”

Williams tried to grin, but it was a sorry effort. Murtch looked again at his watch.

“What time does that Chink restaurant open?”

Williams shook his head.

“What difference——”

“Lot of difference. If I can get that Chink now, I can get him out there on the job before they wake up.”

“We can find out. If they’re not up, we’ll wake ’em.”

Murtch put on his coat and they went to the restaurant. There was no sign of life, so they went to the rear, where the proprietor and his hired help slept in a sort of a shed-like annex.

Murtch hammered on the door and a sleepy-eyed Celestial shuffled into view. It was the proprietor of the restaurant, and to him Murtch explained what he wanted.

“Yo’ want same boy like yo’ take before?”

“Yeah, the same one. Catchum good job. Same ranch.”

The Chinaman turned and hurled a volley of words toward the rear of the shed. Began a conversation which lasted fully a minute. Then the proprietor shook his head.

“Boy say no.”

“Lemme see him,” said Murtch, and a moment later the Chinaman came to the door.

“Good job this time, John,” explained Murtch. “You go with me and take charge of the same ranch-house.”

“Same place we go before?”

“Yeah, same place, John.”

“No can do.”

“No can do! Whatcha talkin’ about? This good job?”

“No can do,” said the Chinaman stolidly, and went back to his bed.

The proprietor shut the door softly and barred it from within.

Murtch and Williams went back to the street.

“Whatcha goin’ to do?” queried Murtch. “There ain’t no other chinks and we can’t get a white cook. If you’d had any sense you’d ’a’ left the old woman there.”

“Things are in an awful tangle,” agreed Williams. “An awful tangle.”

“Now, that made a —— of an impression on my mind,” said Murtch angrily. “You’ve balled up everything. I’ll go out and explain things to Miss Cleveland. She’s got such —— good ideas, such as nailing up bunk-house doors and posting notices—mebbe she’ll see a way out of this.”

Murtch hurried after his horse and rode toward the NR ranch. It was daylight now, and Murtch hoped he would not meet any of the NR cowpunchers. Not that Murtch was afraid, but their rough humor was too pointed to suit him.

About two miles out of town he ran into them. There was no way to dodge them, so he drew up in the center of the road and tried to think of a reason for being there so early in the morning. He inwardly cursed Eph Williams for nailing that bunk-house door.

Then he saw that there was a fourth man, roped to his saddle and riding in an unusual position. They drew up near him, their faces very serious, and waited for him to speak. He knew at a glance who the fourth rider was and he frowned wonderingly.

“Somebody shot him,” offered Wheezer. “We found him and was takin’ him to the doctor.”

Murtch rode in closer to Hardy and tried to get a look at his face.

“He ain’t dead, is he?”

“Wasn’t when we started,” said Chet, “but he ain’t in the best of health right now.”

“No?” Murtch glanced around at them. “Where did yuh find him?”

He emphasized “find” very strongly.

“None of that!” snapped Wheezer quickly. “We didn’t have nothin’ to do with it. Hardy tried to bushwhack somebody and got leaded for his trouble.”

“Did, eh? Who was that somebody?”

“We dunno.”

“Dunno, eh? Where’s Kleig?”

“Dunno that either.”

“Thasso?”

“Why argue with the danged fool?” queried Wooden-shoe. “He’s got his mind fixed. Give him his second-hand deputy and let’s go back and finish our sleep.”

“That’s a good idea,” agreed Wheezer, handing the lead rope to Murtch. “He can take better care of Hardy than we can.”

“Wait a minute!” snapped Murtch. “You can’t pull nothing like that. You come back with me—all of yuh.”

“Yuh mean to arrest us?” asked Wheezer.

“That’s what I mean to do.”

“All right,” grinned Chet. “We’ll remember it.”

Murtch clamped his jaws and looked them over. Here were three men who had no respect for him nor the law. He knew it would be useless to insist on them going back to Broken Butte with him; not only useless, but dangerous as well. But he was willing to try and bluff them.

“Yuh know what it means to resist an officer?”

“Did somebody resist yuh, Murtch?” asked Wheezer.

Murtch studied them for a moment and tightened upon the lead rope.

“All right,” he said meaningly. “I asked yuh to come with me and yuh refused, remember. Next time I want yuh I’ll bring men enough to take yuh.”

“Kind of a mass meetin’, eh?” grinned Chet. “Mebbe we won’t stay for yore party, sheriff.”

“You’d be —— wise not to!” snapped Murtch as he turned and rode away, leading Hardy’s horse.

The three cowboys watched him for several minutes, but he did not look back. Then they whirled their horses and went back toward the ranch.

“We’ll pack what stuff we want and fade out,” said Chet. “There’s no use takin’ any chances. If he once gets us behind the bars—*adios*.”

“What about Leather?” asked Wheezer. “I ain’t goin’ to fog away without hearin’ from him. If he was the one that nailed Clay Hardy he’ll show up or send us word.”

“What do you think, Wooden-shoe?” asked Chet.

“I been wonderin’. Ain’t it kinda funny that the sheriff advised us to pull out of here? That ain’t accordin’ to my idea of what a sheriff ought to do. He can’t hold us for what happened to Clay Hardy.”

“If he does, he can,” observed Chet. “And if they ever put the deadwood on us for all this rustlin’—whoeee! Nawsir, I can’t see myself waitin’ for him to come out with a posse. Williams knows that we loaded this range with cattle, and I don’t trust that jasper a-tall. Mebbe Leather had the right idea in tellin’ him—I dunno.”

They found Miss Cleveland on the porch of the ranch-house, and from her appearance, she had slept little. She was not the imperious lady of the day before, and seemed rather glad to see the three punchers.

“Howdy,” greeted Wheezer, as they dismounted. “Nice morning, ain’t it, ma’am.”

“Yes, it—it’s very nice. Did you just come from town?”

“Well, not quite from town, ma’am. Yuh see, a man got kinda shot up down there by the gate this mornin’, and we had to take him in.”

“A man got shot! Oh, I heard the shots! Who—how did it happen?”

“Some feller pulled the trigger,” explained Wheezer. “Jist like blooie, blooie, blooie! Three times.”

Wheezer held out his hand and went through the motions of pulling the trigger three times.

“But who was it?”

“Nobody you know, ma’am,” said Chet. “One feller laid for the other one. Didn’t amount to nothin’.”

“But I want to know who it was.”

“The one that got shot was Clay Hardy, the deputy sheriff.”

“Was—was he trying to make an arrest?”

“Prob’ly,” said Wheezer dryly. “I wouldn’t put anythin’ past that sheriff’s office.”

The girl looked inquiringly at them and adjusted her tumbled hair.

“Did you see Mr. Williams this morning?” she asked.

“Old fish-eye?” Chet shook his head. “We’re layin’ for him, and I’ll betcha he don’t show up. Wonder when Ma is goin’ to have breakfast ready.”

“Oh!” Miss Cleveland looked curiously at him and frowned slightly. “Didn’t you—er—Mrs. Coogan is not here. Mr. Williams took her to town last night.”

“Oh, yeah.”

Chet rubbed his chin and nodded slowly. Wheezer and Wooden-shoe squinted at each other and back at Miss Cleveland.

“Went to town, did she?” asked Wheezer. “That’s funny.”

“Mr. Williams took her,” repeated the girl. “He said he would bring me another cook early this morning.”

“Said he would,” parroted Wheezer. “Whatcha know?”

“Ma’am,” said Wooden-shoe, “I don’t reckon you *sabe* about Ma Coogan. Mebbe folks has told yuh wrong.”

“You lemme do the talkin’,” Wheezer interposed impatiently. “You don’t want no Chinese cook. You——”

“Are you running this ranch?” asked Miss Cleveland, but her voice was a trifle weak, and she seemed to force herself to be stern.

Wheezer laughed softly and shook his head.

“No, ma’am, I ain’t. Yo’re the owner and boss, but we know this here ranch better than you or that fish-eyed lawyer does. We seen that notice on the bunk-house door and we seen all our stuff piled outside.

“Thassall right. We ain’t wailin’ about that part of it. Ma’s old, ma’am. This is her home. She’s been here a long time, don’tcha know it. Mebbe you had a mother, and if yuh did, and if she was old like Ma, and——”

Wheezer stopped and scratched his head. He had about run out of words. Miss Cleveland bit her lip. She seemed very thoughtful, and the boys waited for her to speak.

“And Ma didn’t have no money,” said Chet softly.

“I—I’m sorry,” said the girl. “I—oh, don’t talk to me! I had to stay alone in that house all night and I never slept at all, and —— such a place!”

She whirled on her heel and fairly ran into the house, leaving the three cowpunchers gawping after her.

“She cusses jist like a human bein’,” said Chet wonderingly. “She said, ‘—— such a place!’ I betcha she’s mad at the old NR.”

They sat down on the steps and rolled smokes. There was no use in them staying at the ranch, and they knew of no place to go.

“We’re in a —— of a fix,” declared Wheezer.

“Wooden-shoe can cook,” observed Chet. “If I could cook I’d go into the kitchen and cook.”

“I ain’t et nothin’ since yesterday noon,” complained Wheezer. “My insides are paralyzed from inaction.”

“I wonder if she’d let me cook?” questioned Wooden-shoe.

“You try it and see.” Miss Cleveland spoke from the doorway. “I had a can of corn for my dinner and I haven’t had anything since. I don’t know how to cook.”

“Lemme at that kitchen,” grinned Wooden-shoe. “I’m plum familiar with food. If the lawyer comes you tell him to tie his chink to the corral-fence, ’cause there’s a horse-thief in the kitchen.”

“Honest?” Miss Cleveland stared at him.

“Well, about as honest as a horse-thief ever gets,” grinned Wooden-shoe, and jingled his spurs into the kitchen.

Murtch lost no time in taking Clay Hardy to a doctor—old Doctor Chisholm, the only M. D. in Broken Butte. He was a tall, very severe old man, whose spectacles were forever threatening to slip off the end of his long nose.

He made a quick examination of Clay Hardy, who had never regained consciousness, and shook his head.

“Sher-r-riff, this is no job for a sur-r-r-geon. Ye are wantin’ the coroner.”

“Is he dead?” asked Murtch quickly.

“I ha’ never seen a deader one, sir.”

Murtch shook his head wearily.

“Well, you’re the coroner, Doc.”

“Aye. How did ye say he came by his wounds?”

“I didn’t say,” growled Murtch. “That —— gang from the NR outfit turned him over to me awhile ago. They told a fool story about some one shootin’ Hardy at the ranch, but don’t know who done it.”

“Then the cir-r-rcumstances calls for an inquest?”

“I think he was murdered.”

“Ha’ ye any idea who would do it?”

“There’s one of the NR outfit missin.’ Name’s Kleig.”

“Weel——” the doctor adjusted his glasses and rubbed his nose thoughtfully—“weel, I suppose we may as well sit on the case in th’ mor-nin.’ Ye will pr-r-roduce the necessary witnesses, sheriff?”

“I’ll come —— near doin’ it,” growled Murtch, and went back to his horse.

He found Williams at his office, a bandage around his head and a frayed cigar clamped between his teeth. Murtch lost no time in telling Williams what had happened to Clay Hardy. For several moments Williams was incoherently explosive, but overcame his feelings enough to try and think calmly.

“What was that —— fool doin’ out there, anyway?”

Murtch shook his head.

“How’d I know? I bawled him out for lettin’ Kleig run that sandy on him, and he got mad about it. Mebbe he tried to salivate Kleig, I dunno.”

“Went out after him, eh?”

Murtch nodded gloomily.

“Looks like it, Eph. Kleig is missing today—so the boys said, but I don’t believe ’em. I’m gittin’ cock-eyed over this thing, I tell yuh.”

“You’ll be lucky if you don’t get worse than that.”

“Thasso?” Murtch flared for a moment, but cooled off quickly. “Mebbe yo’re right, Eph. What in —— is the best thing to do?”

“Well——” Williams rubbed his sore head and smiled sourly—“my advice would be to throw Spade Hollister into jail on a murder charge, raise that one thousand nine hundred and twenty dollars for those four NR thieves and tell ’em to get to —— out of the Broken Butte country.”

“Yuh would, eh?”

“Well, then you suggest something, Murtch.”

“That ranch can’t stand payin’ that much money.”

“You might take a mortgage on the ranch.”

“Aw, ——! I wish somebody’d shot me before I ever heard of the NR. —— old Ralls! —— all his relations!”

“Go ahead and get it out of your system Murtch.”

“All right; —— you along with the rest!”

Murtch got to his feet and stamped to the doorway. There was no doubt but what the sheriff of Broken Butte was both angry and disgusted. He leaned against the door-jamb and glared around.

Suddenly he leaned forward and looked intently toward the Broken Butte hotel. Then he turned and called to Williams—

“Come here!”

Williams joined him and together they watched Chet Wells help Ma Coogan into a buggy, behind which was tied Chet’s saddle-horse, and drive out of town toward the NR ranch.

“What does that mean?” grunted Williams.

Murtch shrugged his shoulders.

“I s’pose it means that you ain’t got a —— of a lot to say about the NR ranch, Eph.”

Williams spat out his frayed cigar and looked gloomily after the departing buggy. Murtch squinted at Williams, as if enjoying the lawyer’s

bitterness.

“Well, what’s the answer?” he asked.

“It won’t suit you, Murtch, but it’s the only solution that I can see. You are going to howl like a wolf, but it’s got to be done. Come back into the office.”

Murtch debated for a moment, after Williams had gone back to his desk, but followed him inside.

Miss Cleveland came out to the ranch-house doorway as Chet drove up to the porch with Ma Coogan. To the new owner of the NR it seemed as though fate was bound to keep Ma Coogan on that ranch. The old lady smiled up at her as Chet helped her out of the buggy.

“Sure, I’m glad and proud to be back,” said Ma happily, “and I’m pleased that ye sent for me, miss.”

“Oh—uh—yes,” faltered the girl, looking hard at Chet, who turned and glanced toward the bunk-house, as if looking for the moral support of the other boys.

Miss Cleveland had not sent for Ma Coogan. Wooden-shoe’s culinary efforts had not been appreciated.

“He means well,” explained Wheezer, “but the food ain’t noways sympathetic enough, ma’am.”

And then Chet Wells had an inspiration.

“Ma’am, do you want to hire a good cook?” he asked.

“It appears that such a person is desired,” she replied, and Chet had appointed himself to employ just such a person. Hence Ma Coogan’s return.

Wheezer and Wooden-shoe came out of the barn, got a glimpse of Ma Coogan on the porch and came up on the run. Chet had not explained who he was going to hire.

Ma Coogan shook hands with them and beamed widely.

“Sure, the old ranch needed me,” she laughed. “Chet tells me that Wooden-shoe set himself up as a cook.”

Wooden-shoe patted her on the back and grinned widely.

“I plumb ruined the food to git yuh back,” he explained. “I’m smart, I am.”

“But not as smart as Chet,” stated Wheezer, looking at Miss Cleveland. Ma laughed and turned to the girl.

“God bless ye, miss. Ye dunno how much happiness it gives me to be back here. Sure, the world wasn’t much for the old lady away from here. Ye can’t understand. It’s just home to me—and the children—” She smiled affectionately at the cowboys. “Ye are children, so ye are. I had four fine little boys when I went away, and I’ve four little boys and a little girl when I came back.”

She threw one arm around Miss Cleveland and gave her a squeeze, before she went into the house. Wheezer lifted his shoulders in a sigh of relief. Miss Cleveland turned from watching Ma Coogan and looked straight into Wheezer’s solemn eyes.

“Yuh ain’t sorry she came back, are yuh, ma’am?” he asked softly.

“Sorry?” The girl stared at him unblinkingly for a moment and turned toward the door. “No, I’m not sorry—I—I think I’m glad.”

“Then there’s four glads around here,” said Chet slowly. “Ma’s a dinger, y’betcha.”

She went into the house and in a few minutes they heard her talking to Ma Coogan.

“Yuh got more brains than I gave yuh credit for, Chet,” said Wheezer. “I never figured yuh was thinkin’ about bringin’ Ma back here. What’ll Williams say?”

“He’s all through sayin’ things about Ma,” said Chet. “Me and that Jasper is goin’ to lock horns, if he comes out here again. I seen him and Murtch in Williams’ office, and they was watchin’ us leave.”

“Didja hear anybody talkin’ about Clay Hardy?” asked Wooden-shoe.

“Nope. I wasn’t doin’ no talkin’. Broken Butte didn’t seem much stirred up about it.”

It was possibly an hour later that Murtch and Williams rode up to the NR on horseback. The three cowboys met them at the door of the ranch-house, but there was no welcome in their greetings.

Williams smiled in a sickly way as he said:

“Well, I see that you brought the old lady back here. Good idea. Was thinking about it myself.”

“With a reverse English,” nodded Wheezer seriously.

“Not at all.”

Williams smiled and shook his head, as he glanced around. Then—

“Where is Mr. Kleig?”

“My ——!” grunted Chet. “Mister Kleig!”

“We dunno where he is,” replied Wooden-shoe.

“I see,” nodded Williams meaningly. “Perhaps you might be able to find him later. At any rate—” He drew a bulky package from his pocket and opened it—“I have drawn one thousand nine hundred and twenty dollars against the NR estate to be paid to you four men for services rendered. I shall have to entrust you with four hundred and eighty of it for Mr. Kleig.”

Wheezer started to cuff his hat to one side of his head, but the blow sent the sombrero spinning off the porch. Wooden-shoe sagged at the waist and his hand went uncertainly to his mouth; while Chet merely kicked himself on the ankle with his spurred heel.

Murtch tried to smile, but it faded quickly.

“Your year’s salary,” said Murtch thickly, and then seemed to have difficulty clearing his throat.

“Yeah—year’s salary,” parroted Wheezer foolishly, as he watched Williams separate the four payments.

“I have talked it over with Miss Cleveland,” said Williams, handing them each the money and giving Leather’s share to Wheezer, “and we decided to meet your claims. Perhaps it is hardly legal, but, under the circumstances, and out of the goodness of her heart, she decided to do this.”

“All I can say is ‘hurrah for our side!’ ” grunted Wooden-shoe. “My gosh!”

He looked down at the money and his nose fairly quivered.

“Have you any plans?” asked Williams.

“Plans?” Chet looked up quickly. “My ——, yuh don’t need plans when you’ve got a year’s salary in yore hand.”

“I’ll take her as she comes,” declared Wheezer, trying to be serious.

“You will be leaving this range soon?” Williams’ tone was suggestive as well as interrogatory.

“Mebbe,” nodded Wheezer. “Yuh can’t sometimes always tell.”

“I had an idea that you’d leave as soon as you got that money.”

“Yeah?” Chet pocketed his money and grinned widely. “Cowboys, lemme at that old roulette. I’m goin’ hawg wild and bull strong.”

“I’ve got the good system,” offered Wooden-shoe. “All yuh got to do _____”

Murtch snorted disgustedly, and Wooden-shoe stopped.

“What’s a matter with you?” he demanded. “Ain’t a feller got a right to have a system?”

“Didja find out who shot Hardy?” asked Wheezer, who wanted to promote peace.

“Naw!” snarled Murtch. “But I’m goin’ to, by ——! And when I do, he’ll hang!”

“I betcha,” nodded Wheezer. “You won’t even wait for judge nor jury, Murtch. Right now yo’re mad at something, ain’tcha? You’ve got a terrible disposition.”

Murtch snorted something unintelligible and stamped back to his horse, but Williams went into the house, where he engaged in conversation with Miss Cleveland. The three cowboys sat down on the steps and looked at each other queerly.

It was more money than they had ever had—all at one time. They were not entitled to it, that much was sure.

“I wonder if they’re goin’ to give Ma some money,” said Wheezer softly. “I betcha that girl has done felt sorry for what she done. I hate to take her money.”

“So do I,” nodded Chet. “Mebbe I’ll pay it back to her some day—mebbe.”

Williams came out and hesitated for a moment before he told them of the inquest.

“I suppose you boys will have to be there to tell what you know about it.”

“Yeah,” agreed Chet. “We’ll come early. Fact is, I reckon we’ll start pretty soon. Yuh goin’ to have Miss Cleveland? She heard the shots fired.”

Williams frowned slightly, but went back into the house for a few minutes. When he came out he told them that Miss Cleveland would attend

the inquest.

“It will be a good chance for her to meet some of the Broken Butte folks,” he added, and went to his horse.

Murtch did not speak to him, and they rode silently away from the ranch.

Williams and Murtch had hardly reached Broken Butte before Wheezer, Chet and Wooden-shoe came in sight of town. Their future was a pink haze of riotous living and their horses’ legs were not swift enough. They pounded into town, barely took time to stable their horses and headed for the Shoshone.

They were questioned regarding the shooting of Clay Hardy, which, under ordinary circumstances, would have given them food for much conversation and argument, but with four hundred and eighty dollars apiece—they were tongue-tied.

Battler Morgan grinned widely and pointed at the ceiling, which meant that there was no limit. Murtch looked into the Shoshone, groaned bitterly, spat viciously and went away. Wheezer had put Leather’s money into his boot, rather than to entrust it to any one.

It was nearly daylight the next morning when Chet and Wooden-shoe bumped into each other at the doorway, as they were both going out.

“Whazza matter?” asked Chet owlishly. “Doorsh too li’l f’r you, par’ner?”

“Thaz’ ri’,” clucked Wooden-shoe, hanging to a porch-post, which seemed to sway him about. “Whazza m’r with you, eh? Shame y’shef?”

“Broke,” dismally. “Money all gone and shomebody stole m’ rudder. Can’t steer m’shef.”

“Ep’demic,” hiccoughed Wooden-shoe. “Ter’ble ep’demic. Awful losh of life. Blew m’ shubstanch in ri’tous livin’. Whazza use?”

“Poor li’l girl,” wailed Chet, suddenly becoming remorseful. “Lied her out of for’shun. Shame m’shef, y’betcha. Poo-o-or li’l girl.”

“Thash ri’,” sobbed Wooden-shoe, getting into the spirit of the occasion. “Poo-o-o-or li’l girl. Oh, my gosh! Poo-o-o-or li’l thing!”

And together they sobbed tearfully, remorsefully, trying to pat each other on the back at a distance of eight feet apart.

The cool air revived them somewhat and after a time they quit crying and became dignified. There was a lighted lamp in Williams' office. Chet's eyes focused upon it.

"Wooden-shoe," he said seriously, "our lawyer is indushtrious. Works night 'n day. Let's go and shee him. What yuh shay? Mebbe we can think of shomethin' he ain't paid for, eh?"

"Sh-sure," stuttered Wooden-shoe. "Never can tell. We've had a nice night f'r thish time of the year. You go 'head, Chet, 'cause you know the way acrosh better'n I do."

They started out in single-file, but cross-currents interfered, and at times they were fifty feet apart.

They finally reached the sidewalk on the opposite side of the street, but below Williams' office.

"Mus' 'a' been cloud-bursht," observed Wooden-shoe. "Never sheen the river so swift before. Mus' 'a' had to git off and swim, don'tcha know it. I'm all wet."

"'S'nawful current right here," admitted Chet thickly. "C'mon."

They started up the street, bumping into the wooden sidewalk at intervals, but managed to reach the corner of Williams' office.

Wooden-shoe began to laugh hoarsely.

"'S'all right, Chet. I thought I fell in river, but 's only a bottle of hooch busted in m' hip-pocket."

Chet slid across the sidewalk and peered into the office window. Williams was there, sitting at his desk, and just in front of the desk stood a man, with his back toward the window. Wooden-shoe crawled over and peered into the window.

Williams was hunched back in his chair, saying nothing, but the other man was tensed forward, talking rapidly. As Chet's eyes began to focus properly he saw Murtch leaning against the wall, partly in the shadow, and about six feet from the man who was talking.

The conversation was pitched too low for Chet or Wooden-shoe to hear what was being said, but they knew that it was a heated argument. Neither of the cowboys were eavesdroppers; so they crawled to the corner, dropped their feet over the edge of the high sidewalk and sat with their backs to the street.

“Whozat arguin’ in there?” asked Wooden-shoe.

“Tha’s Hollister, the crooked gambler.”

“Zasso? I wonder——”

Came the thud of a muffled shot, and the corner of the building, against which Chet was leaning his shoulder, jarred slightly. At the same instant the lamp went out.

Chet and Wooden-shoe promptly fell off the sidewalk and landed on their hands and knees.

“Sh-h-h!” cautioned Chet, as they turned around and poked their heads above the sidewalk. There was not a sound for a minute or so; and then a door closed softly. It sounded like it might be the rear door of Williams’ office.

Then the front door opened and Williams came out. He lighted a cigar, surveyed the street for a few moments and walked slowly away.

“Whatcha think?” queried Wooden-shoe, poking his head above the level of the sidewalk.

“Yes,” grunted Chet enigmatically. “Let’s go down to the livery-stable and find a soft place to sleep.”

“But what was the shootin’ about?” persisted Wooden-shoe. “There was a shot fired in there as sure as——”

“Tha’s none of my business—in my condition,” declared Chet. “C’mon and sleep it off.”

The inquest had been fairly well advertised by word of mouth, and quite a crowd gathered in Broken Butte. Clay Hardy was not popular. Had he been killed in an open fight, or if his slayer was known, there would have been little interest shown. But there was an element of mystery, which always appeals.

Williams had sent a man out to the NR ranch after Miss Cleveland, and he had brought Ma Coogan along. The inquest was to be held in Williams’ office, which was hardly large enough to accommodate a crowd.

Chairs had been brought from the Shoshone Saloon and placed in orderly rows. Doctor Chisholm, with the able assistance of “Judge” Myers, a justice of the peace, conducted the inquest.

Chet and Wooden-shoe slept late in the hay-loft of the livery-stable, and were hardly in physical shape to enjoy the proceedings. Wheezer had not slept, but his winnings amounted to seven hundred dollars and he was vocally jubilant.

The three of them managed to worm themselves to a point of vantage near the middle of the room, in spite of Murtch trying to keep them back. It was hot in that packed room, and the three cowboys wished that they were outside.

“Slim” Carey, proprietor of the stage-office, Gus Welch, a restaurant keeper, Buck Harmon, owner of the Box-H, “Peewee” Sorenson, blacksmith, Jud Reeves, owner of the livery-stable and King Cole, were chosen as a coroner’s jury.

Wheezer Bell was the first witness, and he perspired copiously over his explanation of what happened at the gateway of the NR ranch. Murtch asked him where Leather Kleig was at that time, but Wheezer did not know.

Murtch testified as to how he had taken possession of Clay Hardy’s body, and that the three cowboys had stated that Clay had tried to bushwhack some one.

“The bullet holes r-r-ranged downward,” stated Doctor Chisholm, indicating the angle with a poke of a forefinger. “He was shot fr-r-rom above.”

“Didn’t he have trouble with Kleig?” questioned Buck Harmon.

“Hol’ on!” snapped Chet. “If Leather had killed Hardy he wouldn’t ’a’ run away, y’betcha.”

“You’re not a witness, Wells,” advised Murtch.

“The —— I’m not!”

“Order!” yelled the judge, hammering on the desk. “One more remark like that and out you go.”

“Gimme a chance and I’ll go before that,” retorted Chet. “This danged place would cook a ham.”

“He had trouble with Kleig,” said Murtch, ignoring Chet and speaking to Harmon. “Kleig shoved a gun in his ribs——”

“Sa-a-ay!” interrupted Wheezer. “Where’s the jasper that Clay was framin’ to shoot in that poker game?”

Murtch turned and spoke to the judge, who shook his head quickly. Murtch turned back, saying—

“Kleig disappeared that night and——”

“I asked a lady-like question and can’t git no answer,” wailed Wheezer. “Where’s that gambler?”

The judge rapped sharply again and glared at Wheezer.

“I told you once that I’d put——”

“Try doin’ it,” invited Wheezer. “I want to know where that gambler is. He’s the jasper that knows.”

“Do we have to suffer all these interruptions from three drunken cowpunchers?” asked Williams angrily.

“Who’s drunk?” demanded Wooden-shoe, and started to get up, but Wheezer drew him back.

“Ar-r-re we goin’ to make this a place of hecklin’ and blatherin’, or do we pr-r-roceed with the inquest?” burred the doctor impatiently.

“Are we sure that this shootin’ was done at the NR ranch?” asked Slim Carey. Slim was very slow in his speech, which was partly muffled by a huge chew of tobacco.

“Miss Cleveland heard the shots,” offered Williams.

Miss Cleveland nodded quickly and waited for him to question her, but the jury seemed to take it as conclusive evidence. Every one in the room endeavored to catch a glimpse of the new ranch-owner.

“Miss Jane Cleveland inherited the NR ranch from her uncle, Nick Ralls,” explained Williams.

There was a shuffling of feet and several talked in undertones. Suddenly a man came worming his way through the crowd. It was a cowboy from the Box-H, and he was excited, as he called to Murtch.

“Sheriff, I found a dead man down in Cannonball Gulch! He’s been shot and looks like he’d been dumped over the edge.”

Cannon-ball Gulch paralleled the stage-road, and was only about a mile from Broken Butte.

“Who was he, Bud?” asked Harmon.

“I dunno him. Looks like a gambler t’ me.”

“That’s the feller!” exclaimed Wheezer. “Name’s Hollister, or somethin’ like that.”

Miss Cleveland had got to her feet and was staring at Wheezer, while she grasped the back of the chair in front of her. The place was momentarily in an uproar.

“That’s the feller that Hardy had the trouble with!” yelled Wheezer. “I’ll betcha——”

“Don’t you go to bettin’ too much!” rasped Murtch, half-yelling his words.

“Order!” yelled the judge. “Set down and shut up!”

Miss Cleveland ignored every one and forced her way to Wheezer.

“Say that name again,” she panted. “Was it Hollister?”

“Yeah—they called him Spade, ma’am.”

“Spade Hollister!”

The girl gasped out the name and stared at Williams. He had heard her, and his cheeks went pale. His fishy eyes shifted quickly to Murtch. There was so much conversation that only those vitally interested were paying any attention to the girl.

The cowboy was explaining to those around him how he had accidentally run across the body. It was not in a place where it would be easily discovered. Chet got to his feet and put a hand on the girl’s arm, as he looked at Murtch and Williams.

“Say, do yuh want me to tell yuh who killed that Hollister?”

Murtch jerked back, as if afraid, but hunched forward again, staring at Chet. Williams grasped Murtch by the arm, trying to gain his attention, but Murtch was waiting for Chet to speak again.

“What do you know about that murder?” asked Jud Reeves.

But before Chet could tell what he knew, there came a mutter of voices, the shifting of feet, and in through the crowd came Leather Kleig and a young woman. She was a stranger to Broken Butte.

Kleig was grinning. He stopped near the center of the room and glanced around.

“Heard somebody say that I got here just in time,” Leather smiled widely. Murtch and Williams were staring at him. He turned and looked at Miss Cleveland, whose face was white.

“I reckon I got here in time,” continued Leather. “I didn’t know that Clay Hardy was dead. Yuh see—” He glanced around the room—“I had an idea that even a lawyer can make mistakes. Mister Williams I’d like to have yuh meet Miss Jane Cleveland, the new owner of the NR ranch.”

Leather indicated the girl with him, and a gasp of surprise went up from the crowd.

“What do you mean, Kleig?” Williams’ voice was hoarse with anger and fear.

“What do I mean?”

Leather leaned forward. His smile was gone now, and the lines about his eyes were drawn tightly.

“I mean that you picked the wrong girl, Williams. You helped the old man make out his will, and you saw a chance to steal the ranch; so you picked the wrong heiress. Murtch was in on the deal.”

“That’s a lie!” Murtch fairly screamed his denial.

Leather turned to Miss Cleveland—

“Did you know Spade Hollister?”

The room fell silent. For a moment she stared straight ahead, and then—

“Yes. Spade Hollister was my sweetheart.”

“And, by ——, Murtch and Williams killed him!” yelled Chet. “I seen ’em together, and me and Wooden-shoe heard the shot!”

“Murtch killed him!” screamed Williams, “I——”

Williams’ confession, or accusation, was cut short. Murtch had whirled sidewise and fired his six-shooter so close to Williams’ side that the report was only a jarring thud.

As Williams fell, Murtch whirled on the crowd like a cornered wolf, but Leather’s gun was spouting lead into him and he went down cursing thickly.

“Good boy!” yelled King Cole. “He’d ’a’ killed like a coyote with the rabies. God! What a mess!”

The room was in an uproar. Doctor Chisholm lifted Williams’ head and Leather crowded in close. Williams was conscious, but evidently knew that

he was passing fast. He sneered at Leather and spat a curse.

“Open my safe,” he croaked to the doctor. “Key’s in my pocket. Quick.”

The doctor took out the key and opened the safe.

“The package with the rubber band,” croaked Williams.

He slipped the band loose and peered at the papers wonderingly. What he looked for was not there.

“Look in the safe!” he panted. “Find—paper.”

“She’s plumb empty, Williams,” said the judge.

“Empty?” Williams nodded weakly and peered up at Leather. “I guess you win, Kleig. I might as well tell it all. Miss Cleveland is a honkatonk actress and we got her to play this part.

“Hollister was stuck on her, —— him! He found out something and came here to ask for his share and to see that she wasn’t harmed. I guess he killed Clay Hardy. He demanded five thousand dollars, or would tell that it was a crooked deal. Murtch shot him.

“Murtch had Clay frame it to kill Hollister in that poker game, but you spoiled that. We were going to buy the NR from—her—for—one—dollar.”

Williams laughed chokingly.

“You know what ruined our scheme, Kleig. Too—many—crooks.”

He rolled sidewise and his head pillowed on his arm.

“It’s a good thing we ain’t got nothin’ to arrest,” said Wooden-shoe foolishly. “We ain’t got no sheriff nor lawyer. What do yuh reckon he was lookin’ for in the safe?”

“I’ll take char-r-rge now,” said the doctor wearily. “And I per-r-rsume there won’t be any inquest.”

The crowd moved back to the street. Ma Coogan was trying to “mother” Miss Cleveland, or rather the one who had been Miss Cleveland, and get acquainted with the real Miss Cleveland at the same time.

Leather Kleig drew King Cole aside and they walked down the street together, while the other three cowboys went to the livery-stable to arrange transportation back to the ranch for the women. When King Cole and Leather came back, the two-seated spring-wagon had drawn up to the sidewalk, with Chet driving.

Leather motioned to him to get down, and then spoke directly to the new owner of the NR.

“Like I told yuh before, ma’am, the ranch ain’t nothin’ for a lady to run. Mister Cole kinda wants to buy the place, as soon as the papers can be fixed up, and he offers a good price.

“Yuh better just stay here at the hotel until it is all fixed up, which will take a week or so. Ma will stay with yuh, of course.”

He turned and put a hand on Ma’s shoulder.

“Yo’re fixed for life, Ma. Miss Cleveland insists that yuh take the money from the sale of the ranch and live easy the rest of yore life.”

“But—but—” spluttered Ma Coogan, bewildered.

“That is true,” replied the young lady. “I feel that it should belong to you.”

“Hurrah f’r our side!” blurted Wooden-shoe.

“Sure, and what will become of you boys?” asked Ma Coogan anxiously. “Isn’t there money enough——”

“We’ve got jobs down in the lower end of the valley,” assured Leather, “and we’ll see yuh once in a while.”

It was two hours later that the four cowboys rode away from the NR ranch. They had gone back to get their belongings, and each man had a bulging war-sack tied behind the cantle of his saddle.

“Now will yuh tell us where we’re goin’?” asked Wheezer, as they halted at the top of a hog-back ridge and looked back at the old ranch-house.

Leather laughed softly and looped one leg around his saddle-horn while he rolled a cigaret.

“I was suspicious of Williams,” he said slowly. “He was too —— interested, don’tcha know it? They wanted all of us off the place. I smelled a crooked deal.

“Then when they tried to kill Hollister, I knowed he was mixed up in it. Well, I wasn’t so danged sure about any will bein’ made out, so I out-smarted old Williams, knocked him on the head, opened his safe and put the key back in his pocket.

“That will was what he was lookin’ for in that bundle of papers. I dunno what he ever saved it for, ’cause that was what cinched the deadwood on to him. I slipped out of town and headed for Keogh. I didn’t know what luck I was goin’ to have, but——”

“Hold on,” interrupted Wheezer. “Do yuh mean to say that yuh got the will that old Nick made out?”

“Yeah—sure.” Leather scratched a match and lighted his cigaret. “Their will was a forgery.”

“Then why didn’t yuh jist show the will and——”

“Nope,” Leather inhaled deeply and shook his head. “I’ll show yuh why.” He took a legal-looking document from inside his shirt and opened it.

“This is the will that Ma Coogan witnessed. It gives the whole —— NR ranch to us four fellers.”

“To us!” blurted Chet. “Whatcha mean?”

“That’s what the will says, Chet. Us four fellers owned every danged stick and stone on the NR.”

“Well, but—goshdang it, talk can’t yuh?” croaked Wooden-shoe. “Where does this Miss Cleveland come in?”

“Her name wasn’t Cleveland—not mine wasn’t. Her name was Hollister once. Spade Hollister was her husband. He mistreated her awful, and I danged near killed him for it. Now, she’s married to a good feller and they’re doin’ fine. She’s my sister.”

“Oh, my gosh!” exploded Wheezer. “And you got her to—I getcha, Leather.”

“Yeah,” nodded Leather. “I knowed how yuh all felt about Ma Coogan, and that’s the only way I could figure to fix her up for life. And her money’ll be clean, too.

“I told the whole thing to King Cole, and gave him a list of what we stole for the NR. He’s goin’ to tell these different outfits and see that they take back their stock and keep still about it.

“And he’s goin’ to pay Ma a good price for the NR and what honestly belongs there. My sister will see that it is all done on the level.”

Leather grinned softly and touched a match to the document as he said—

“Ma wouldn’t touch a crooked nickel, but she don’t have to now.”

“Where’s the jobs yuh spoke about, Leather?” queried Wheezer.

“Somewhere,” smiled Leather. “There ought to be jobs for honest and capable cowpunchers somewhere, hadn’t there?”

Wheezer nodded solemnly, as he said:

“Y’betcha, cowboy. I take back what I’ve said about old Nick Ralls. He meant to shoot square, but he never figured Ma in on the game; so we’ll jist call it a misdeal.”

Leather nodded as he pinched out the fire on the remaining corner of the will and crumpled it into a tiny ball, which he tossed aside.

Then, as if by mutual consent, they turned from looking at the old ranch-house and rode out of sight over the hog-back.

Transcriber’s Note: This story appeared in the June 30, 1923 issue of *Adventure* magazine.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE MISDEAL

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

Creating the works from print editions not protected by U.S. copyright law means that no one owns a United States copyright in these works, so the Foundation (and you!) can copy and distribute it in the United States without permission and without paying copyright royalties. Special rules, set forth in the General Terms of Use part of this license, apply to copying and distributing Project Gutenberg™ electronic works to protect the PROJECT GUTENBERG™ concept and trademark. Project Gutenberg is a registered trademark, and may not be used if you charge for an eBook, except by following the terms of the trademark license, including paying royalties for use of the Project Gutenberg trademark. If you do not charge anything for copies of this eBook, complying with the trademark license is very easy. You may use this eBook for nearly any purpose such as creation of derivative works, reports, performances and research. Project Gutenberg eBooks may be modified and printed and given away—you may do practically ANYTHING in the United States with eBooks not protected by U.S. copyright law. Redistribution is subject to the trademark license, especially commercial redistribution.

START: FULL LICENSE

THE FULL PROJECT GUTENBERG™ LICENSE

PLEASE READ THIS BEFORE YOU DISTRIBUTE OR USE THIS WORK

To protect the Project Gutenberg™ mission of promoting the free distribution of electronic works, by using or distributing this work (or any other work associated in any way with the phrase “Project Gutenberg”), you agree to comply with all the terms of the Full Project Gutenberg License available with this file or online at www.gutenberg.org/license.

Section 1. General Terms of Use and Redistributing Project Gutenberg electronic works

1.A. By reading or using any part of this Project Gutenberg electronic work, you indicate that you have read, understand, agree to and accept all the terms of this license and intellectual property (trademark/copyright) agreement. If you do not agree to abide by all the terms of this agreement, you must cease using and return or destroy all copies of Project Gutenberg electronic works in your possession. If you paid a fee for obtaining a copy of or access to a Project Gutenberg electronic work and you do not agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement, you may obtain a refund from the person or entity to whom you paid the fee as set forth in paragraph 1.E.8.

1.B. “Project Gutenberg” is a registered trademark. It may only be used on or associated in any way with an electronic work by people who agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement. There are a few things that you can do with most Project Gutenberg electronic works even without complying with the full terms of this agreement. See paragraph 1.C below. There are a lot of things you can do with Project Gutenberg electronic works if you follow the terms of this agreement and help preserve free future access to Project Gutenberg electronic works. See paragraph 1.E below.

1.C. The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation (“the Foundation” or PGLAF), owns a compilation copyright in the collection of Project Gutenberg electronic works. Nearly all the individual works in the collection are in the public domain in the United States. If an individual

work is unprotected by copyright law in the United States and you are located in the United States, we do not claim a right to prevent you from copying, distributing, performing, displaying or creating derivative works based on the work as long as all references to Project Gutenberg are removed. Of course, we hope that you will support the Project Gutenberg mission of promoting free access to electronic works by freely sharing Project Gutenberg works in compliance with the terms of this agreement for keeping the Project Gutenberg name associated with the work. You can easily comply with the terms of this agreement by keeping this work in the same format with its attached full Project Gutenberg License when you share it without charge with others.

1.D. The copyright laws of the place where you are located also govern what you can do with this work. Copyright laws in most countries are in a constant state of change. If you are outside the United States, check the laws of your country in addition to the terms of this agreement before downloading, copying, displaying, performing, distributing or creating derivative works based on this work or any other Project Gutenberg work. The Foundation makes no representations concerning the copyright status of any work in any country other than the United States.

1.E. Unless you have removed all references to Project Gutenberg:

1.E.1. The following sentence, with active links to, or other immediate access to, the full Project Gutenberg License must appear prominently whenever any copy of a Project Gutenberg work (any work on which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” appears, or with which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” is associated) is accessed, displayed, performed, viewed, copied or distributed:

*This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in
the United States and most other parts of the world
at no cost and with almost no restrictions
whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use
it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg™*

License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

1.E.2. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is derived from texts not protected by U.S. copyright law (does not contain a notice indicating that it is posted with permission of the copyright holder), the work can be copied and distributed to anyone in the United States without paying any fees or charges. If you are redistributing or providing access to a work with the phrase “Project Gutenberg” associated with or appearing on the work, you must comply either with the requirements of paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 or obtain permission for the use of the work and the Project Gutenberg trademark as set forth in paragraphs 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.3. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is posted with the permission of the copyright holder, your use and distribution must comply with both paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 and any additional terms imposed by the copyright holder. Additional terms will be linked to the Project Gutenberg License for all works posted with the permission of the copyright holder found at the beginning of this work.

1.E.4. Do not unlink or detach or remove the full Project Gutenberg License terms from this work, or any files containing a part of this work or any other work associated with Project Gutenberg.

1.E.5. Do not copy, display, perform, distribute or redistribute this electronic work, or any part of this electronic work, without prominently displaying the sentence set forth in paragraph 1.E.1 with active links or immediate access to the full terms of the Project Gutenberg License.

1.E.6. You may convert to and distribute this work in any binary, compressed, marked up, nonproprietary or proprietary form, including any word processing or hypertext form. However, if you provide access to or

distribute copies of a Project Gutenberg work in a format other than “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other format used in the official version posted on the official Project Gutenberg website (www.gutenberg.org), you must, at no additional cost, fee or expense to the user, provide a copy, a means of exporting a copy, or a means of obtaining a copy upon request, of the work in its original “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other form. Any alternate format must include the full Project Gutenberg License as specified in paragraph 1.E.1.

1.E.7. Do not charge a fee for access to, viewing, displaying, performing, copying or distributing any Project Gutenberg works unless you comply with paragraph 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.8. You may charge a reasonable fee for copies of or providing access to or distributing Project Gutenberg electronic works provided that:

- You pay a royalty fee of 20% of the gross profits you derive from the use of Project Gutenberg works calculated using the method you already use to calculate your applicable taxes. The fee is owed to the owner of the Project Gutenberg trademark, but he has agreed to donate royalties under this paragraph to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation. Royalty payments must be paid within 60 days following each date on which you prepare (or are legally required to prepare) your periodic tax returns. Royalty payments should be clearly marked as such and sent to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation at the address specified in Section 4, “Information about donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation.”
- You provide a full refund of any money paid by a user who notifies you in writing (or by e-mail) within 30 days of receipt that s/he does not agree to the terms of the full Project Gutenberg™ License. You must require such a user to return or destroy all copies of the works possessed in a physical medium and discontinue all use of and all access to other copies of Project Gutenberg™ works.

- You provide, in accordance with paragraph 1.F.3, a full refund of any money paid for a work or a replacement copy, if a defect in the electronic work is discovered and reported to you within 90 days of receipt of the work.
- You comply with all other terms of this agreement for free distribution of Project Gutenberg™ works.

1.E.9. If you wish to charge a fee or distribute a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work or group of works on different terms than are set forth in this agreement, you must obtain permission in writing from the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the manager of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark. Contact the Foundation as set forth in Section 3 below.

1.F.

1.F.1. Project Gutenberg volunteers and employees expend considerable effort to identify, do copyright research on, transcribe and proofread works not protected by U.S. copyright law in creating the Project Gutenberg™ collection. Despite these efforts, Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, and the medium on which they may be stored, may contain “Defects,” such as, but not limited to, incomplete, inaccurate or corrupt data, transcription errors, a copyright or other intellectual property infringement, a defective or damaged disk or other medium, a computer virus, or computer codes that damage or cannot be read by your equipment.

1.F.2. LIMITED WARRANTY, DISCLAIMER OF DAMAGES - Except for the “Right of Replacement or Refund” described in paragraph 1.F.3, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the owner of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark, and any other party distributing a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work under this agreement, disclaim all liability to you for damages, costs and expenses, including legal fees. YOU AGREE THAT YOU HAVE NO REMEDIES FOR NEGLIGENCE, STRICT LIABILITY, BREACH OF WARRANTY OR BREACH OF CONTRACT EXCEPT THOSE PROVIDED IN PARAGRAPH 1.F.3. YOU AGREE

THAT THE FOUNDATION, THE TRADEMARK OWNER, AND ANY DISTRIBUTOR UNDER THIS AGREEMENT WILL NOT BE LIABLE TO YOU FOR ACTUAL, DIRECT, INDIRECT, CONSEQUENTIAL, PUNITIVE OR INCIDENTAL DAMAGES EVEN IF YOU GIVE NOTICE OF THE POSSIBILITY OF SUCH DAMAGE.

1.F.3. LIMITED RIGHT OF REPLACEMENT OR REFUND - If you discover a defect in this electronic work within 90 days of receiving it, you can receive a refund of the money (if any) you paid for it by sending a written explanation to the person you received the work from. If you received the work on a physical medium, you must return the medium with your written explanation. The person or entity that provided you with the defective work may elect to provide a replacement copy in lieu of a refund. If you received the work electronically, the person or entity providing it to you may choose to give you a second opportunity to receive the work electronically in lieu of a refund. If the second copy is also defective, you may demand a refund in writing without further opportunities to fix the problem.

1.F.4. Except for the limited right of replacement or refund set forth in paragraph 1.F.3, this work is provided to you 'AS-IS', WITH NO OTHER WARRANTIES OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR ANY PURPOSE.

1.F.5. Some states do not allow disclaimers of certain implied warranties or the exclusion or limitation of certain types of damages. If any disclaimer or limitation set forth in this agreement violates the law of the state applicable to this agreement, the agreement shall be interpreted to make the maximum disclaimer or limitation permitted by the applicable state law. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision of this agreement shall not void the remaining provisions.

1.F.6. INDEMNITY - You agree to indemnify and hold the Foundation, the trademark owner, any agent or employee of the Foundation, anyone providing copies of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works in accordance

with this agreement, and any volunteers associated with the production, promotion and distribution of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, harmless from all liability, costs and expenses, including legal fees, that arise directly or indirectly from any of the following which you do or cause to occur: (a) distribution of this or any Project Gutenberg work, (b) alteration, modification, or additions or deletions to any Project Gutenberg work, and (c) any Defect you cause.

Section 2. Information about the Mission of Project Gutenberg

Project Gutenberg is synonymous with the free distribution of electronic works in formats readable by the widest variety of computers including obsolete, old, middle-aged and new computers. It exists because of the efforts of hundreds of volunteers and donations from people in all walks of life.

Volunteers and financial support to provide volunteers with the assistance they need are critical to reaching Project Gutenberg's goals and ensuring that the Project Gutenberg collection will remain freely available for generations to come. In 2001, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation was created to provide a secure and permanent future for Project Gutenberg and future generations. To learn more about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation and how your efforts and donations can help, see Sections 3 and 4 and the Foundation information page at www.gutenberg.org.

Section 3. Information about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation is a non-profit 501(c)(3) educational corporation organized under the laws of the state of Mississippi and granted tax exempt status by the Internal Revenue Service. The Foundation's EIN or federal tax identification number is 64-6221541. Contributions to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation are tax

deductible to the full extent permitted by U.S. federal laws and your state's laws.

The Foundation's business office is located at 41 Watchung Plaza #516, Montclair NJ 07042, USA, +1 (862) 621-9288. Email contact links and up to date contact information can be found at the Foundation's website and official page at www.gutenberg.org/contact

Section 4. Information about Donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

Project Gutenberg™ depends upon and cannot survive without widespread public support and donations to carry out its mission of increasing the number of public domain and licensed works that can be freely distributed in machine-readable form accessible by the widest array of equipment including outdated equipment. Many small donations (\$1 to \$5,000) are particularly important to maintaining tax exempt status with the IRS.

The Foundation is committed to complying with the laws regulating charities and charitable donations in all 50 states of the United States. Compliance requirements are not uniform and it takes a considerable effort, much paperwork and many fees to meet and keep up with these requirements. We do not solicit donations in locations where we have not received written confirmation of compliance. To SEND DONATIONS or determine the status of compliance for any particular state visit www.gutenberg.org/donate.

While we cannot and do not solicit contributions from states where we have not met the solicitation requirements, we know of no prohibition against accepting unsolicited donations from donors in such states who approach us with offers to donate.

International donations are gratefully accepted, but we cannot make any statements concerning tax treatment of donations received from outside the United States. U.S. laws alone swamp our small staff.

Please check the Project Gutenberg web pages for current donation methods and addresses. Donations are accepted in a number of other ways including checks, online payments and credit card donations. To donate, please visit: www.gutenberg.org/donate.

Section 5. General Information About Project Gutenberg electronic works

Professor Michael S. Hart was the originator of the Project Gutenberg concept of a library of electronic works that could be freely shared with anyone. For forty years, he produced and distributed Project Gutenberg eBooks with only a loose network of volunteer support.

Project Gutenberg eBooks are often created from several printed editions, all of which are confirmed as not protected by copyright in the U.S. unless a copyright notice is included. Thus, we do not necessarily keep eBooks in compliance with any particular paper edition.

Most people start at our website which has the main PG search facility: www.gutenberg.org.

This website includes information about Project Gutenberg, including how to make donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, how to help produce our new eBooks, and how to subscribe to our email newsletter to hear about new eBooks.